

Thursday, April 9, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why does India's nuclear reactor milestone matter?

BY RITURAJ BARUAH

India moved closer to nuclear fuel self-reliance as its prototype fast breeder reactor in Tamil Nadu achieved criticality on 6 April, the stage of sustained nuclear reaction. This could help India achieve its target of 100GW nuclear capacity by 2047. *Mint* explores the development.



1 What is a fast breeder nuclear reactor?

A fast breeder reactor produces more fuel than it consumes while generating power. India's fast breeder reactor was designed and developed by the Indira Gandhi Centre for Atomic Research, the R&D centre of the Department of Atomic Energy. The reactor has a 500-megawatt electrical (MWe) capacity and uses uranium, plutonium and thorium as fuel at various stages to generate electricity. The reactor is designed to eventually use a widely-found thorium category. Through transmutation, this thorium will be converted into Uranium-233, which will fuel the third stage of India's nuclear power programme.

ISTOCKPHOTO

2 Why is the milestone significant for India?

Firstly, this fast breeder reactor technology was indigenously developed after decades of research, design and engineering. Secondly, once fully operational, India will become the second country after Russia to operate a commercial fast breeder reactor. The US, France, the UK, Japan and China have worked on developing this technology but have not succeeded yet. The Uranium-233 bred from thorium can then be used as fuel for the generation of nuclear power, helping the country reduce dependence on uranium imports and also move towards meeting its green energy ambitions.

3 What is India's nuclear power output now?

India has an installed nuclear power generation capacity of 8,786 MW. Nuclear power plants produced 56,681 million units of electricity in FY25, equivalent to 3.1% of the total electricity generation. India's nuclear capacity is set to grow to 22,386 MW by FY32 with indigenous 700 MW reactors and 1,000 MW reactors, the government has said.

4 What does our nuclear power plan aim for?

The three-stage nuclear power programme of India was envisioned by Homi J. Bhabha in the 1950s. In stage 1, uranium is used in pressurized heavy water reactors to generate power. The spent fuel produces plutonium, the primary input for the next stage. In stage 2, plutonium undergoes fission in fast breeder reactors. In stage 3, uranium is used for a reaction with thorium, which gets converted into uranium and sustains the reaction. This would lead to virtually an unlimited energy output.

5 How is India fostering the nuclear sector?

The Parliament passed the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (Shanti) Bill, 2025, in December. The bill proposed to open up nuclear power generation to the private sector and ease liabilities on suppliers. In the budget for FY26, the government also announced the Nuclear Energy Mission and allocated ₹20,000 crore for the research, design, development and deployment of small modular reactors, aiming to operationalize at least five of them by 2033.

QUICK EDIT

A reflex relief rally

The 14-day ceasefire between the US and Iran sprang Indian shares up on Wednesday, with both benchmark indices ending nearly 4% up, mirroring similar gains in other markets. US President Donald Trump's earlier threat of wiping out a "whole civilization" and Tehran's combative response had frayed investor nerves so badly that the relief felt palpable. The news sent crude oil prices down 14% to under \$95 a barrel even as the rupee strengthened against the dollar. Hopes of a lasting peace deal, however, shouldn't get ahead of the facts. Truce talks are due to begin, but the stated positions of both sides suggest that peace is easier sought than achieved. The direction of stock prices will depend significantly on what happens next. Iran still seems bent on retaining its uranium enrichment facilities and control of the Hormuz shipping passage, both of which may be deal-wreckers for the US; as reported, Iran also wants Israel to back off from Lebanon. Since Tehran appears to see itself as the victor (just as Trump might see himself), what terms it may try to set for other oil producers in the Gulf also remain unclear. For now, though, we can all breathe a little easier. An all-out disaster has been averted.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

Ceasefires are always good news. Especially, if they lead to a just and lasting peace. But this momentary relief cannot make us forget the chaos, the destruction and the lives lost. The Government of Spain will not applaud those who set the world on fire just because they show up with a bucket.

PEDRO SANCHEZ
SPANISH PRIME
MINISTER



INSIDE

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Views | RBI's rate-setting panel is in step with other major central banks **>P13**

DATA BITES

HOW MUCH CARGO DO INDIA'S MAJOR PORTS HANDLE?

Major Indian ports clocked 915 million tonnes of cargo traffic in FY26, up 7.1%. Gujarat's Deendayal Port handled the highest volume (160 million tonnes), up 6.6%, followed by Odisha's Paradip Port.

Cargo traffic handled by India's major ports in FY26

Cargo traffic (in million tonnes)

COLUMNS



DAVID FICKLING



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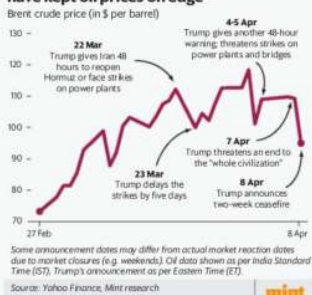
PLAIN FACTS

TOP GLOBAL NEWS A MONTHLY WRAP

BY RUPANJAL CHAUHAN

Every month, *Mint's Plain Facts* section tracks key global data to piece together the biggest developments shaping the world. Through analysis and charts, it explains how these trends are rippling across markets, where they may head in the coming weeks, and whether they could affect India. Global markets are navigating a precarious mix of risks. The war in West Asia, fears of artificial intelligence (AI)-driven job losses and climate risks tied to El Niño are fuelling unease. US President Donald Trump, after issuing threats to Iran, has announced a two-week ceasefire, while central banks remain in a wait-and-watch mode. Layoffs at Oracle have deepened fears about AI's impact on jobs, and El Niño may push global temperatures to a new record high.

Donald Trump's statements on the Iran war have kept oil prices on edge



TENSE TRUCE

IN A matter of hours, US President Donald Trump executed a stunning pivot—from issuing apocalyptic threats to Iran to announcing a two-week conditional ceasefire.

On 7 April, Trump had issued a stark ultimatum on his social media platform Truth Social, warning that "a whole civilization will die tonight" if Iran failed to reopen the Strait of Hormuz by 8 pm Eastern Time (ET).

However, in less than two hours before the deadline, Trump announced a mediation by Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif for a breakthrough agreement. The latest announcements follow a familiar pattern of issuing threats and granting extensions.

On 21 March, Trump had issued a 48-hour ultimatum to Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz or face the obliteration of its power plants, but had backed down, citing "productive talks". Trump's statements have kept the oil market on edge since the beginning of the war, with the latest move triggering a 14-15% decline in oil prices to below \$100 per barrel.

TOUGH SPOT

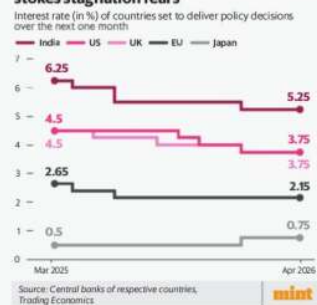
MAJOR CENTRAL banks are expected to remain cautious in the coming weeks as the West Asia war clouds global economic outlook, with supply disruptions and higher oil prices stoking stagflation fears.

The US Federal Reserve, Bank of England, European Central Bank, and Bank of Japan are widely expected to keep interest rates unchanged, balancing the risk of higher inflation against slowing growth.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has already held rates steady. The RBI left its policy rate at 5.25% to support growth. If the war-related risks persist, central banks could tighten interest rates later in the year.

For now, policymakers remain wary of high oil prices and supply crunch weighing on industrial activity, reinforcing a wait-and-watch approach. Central banks are prioritizing stability, signalling that any shift in rates will depend on clearer evidence on inflation and the broader impact of geopolitical tensions on growth.

Rate cuts to be off the table as the Iran war stokes stagflation fears



Unlike Trump's tariffs, the West Asia war has hit all major currencies

Change in values of currencies (in %) against the US dollar during the first 37-day period.



CURRENCY CHANGE

OVER THE past year, two major developments have rattled the entire world: Donald Trump's 'Liberation Day' tariffs and the war in West Asia.

While both threatened to reshape the global order, their impact on the currency movements of different countries varied significantly.

A *Mint* analysis of the first 37 days of each episode shows that the Iran war has put major currencies under significant strain.

During the 2025 tariff episode, the currency market saw a notable divergence, with the euro and Japanese yen strengthening against the US dollar by 4.73% and 4.13%, respectively, suggesting that trade friction helped strengthen major fiat peers.

In contrast, the 2026 West Asia war has triggered a synchronized decline, with Japan and India, both heavily dependent on oil imports, seeing sharper currency losses. The data suggests that conflicts are more likely to push investors towards hard assets than policy-driven disruptions.

ORACLE AXE

AMERICAN TECHNOLOGY company Oracle Corp. laid off around 30,000 employees globally on 31 March, with termination emails reportedly sent without prior notice from human resources or direct managers.

The move is among the largest workforce

Oracle layoffs add to a broader wave of repeated job cuts across big tech firms

Number of employees laid off by major tech companies over the past year

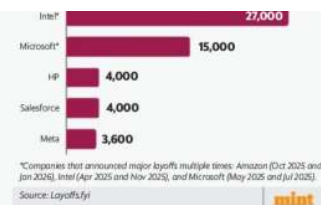


EDUCATIONS IN TENURE YEARS, WITH HINDU THE HIGHEST, accounting for roughly 12,000 job cuts.

The decision comes as Oracle pivots towards cloud infrastructure, particularly Oracle Cloud Infrastructure (OCI), and AI, redirecting resources to compete more directly with Amazon and Google.

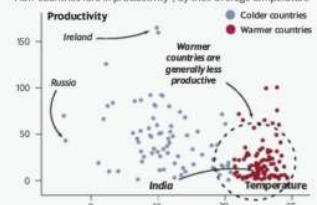
The move ranks among the biggest layoff drives in recent years, surpassing Intel's April 2025 layoffs of about 22,000 employees, according to data from Layoffs.fyi.

It also reflects a broader industry trend, with tech firms cutting jobs as they increase spending on AI. Over 40,000 tech employees have already been laid off in 2026.



El Niño-driven heat may dent productivity, especially in vulnerable economies

How countries fare in productivity*, by their average temperature**



*For productivity, GDP (PPP, constant 2021 \$) per hour worked in 2025 has been used. **For temperature, the 30-year annual average (1995-2020) was taken for the analysis. Countries are split at the median (21.1°C): above = warmer, below = colder.

Source: International Labour Organization, World Bank

EL NIÑO RISKS

WITH THE world expected to experience El Niño, warm ocean currents that raise global temperatures, 2026 could see a new record, surpassing the previous high of 1.5 degrees Celsius above the 1850-1900 pre-industrial level seen in 2024.

Higher temperatures can weigh on agricultural activity and productivity. Several studies link rising heat with lower output, a trend reflected in the data.

A Mint analysis of productivity and temperature data showed that countries with warmer average climates tend to have lower output per worker (measured by GDP per hour worked), pointing to structural vulnerability to heat.

If El Niño does develop—as predicted by the World Meteorological Organization by mid-2026—it could trigger frequent heatwaves and disrupt rainfall patterns, and pose risks to India's monsoon. Combined with the West Asia war, already straining economic activity and food supply due to higher fertilizer prices, El Niño could add to global economic pressures.

CHENNAI NEW DELHI MUMBAI BANGALURU KOLKATA AHMEDABAD HYDERABAD PUNE

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Kerala's fiscal mess looms over the ballot box P10



Foreign audiences are getting hooked to Indian content P5

SENSEX 77,562.90 ↑ 2,946.32 NIFTY 23,997.35 ↑ 873.7 DOLLAR ₹92.54 ↓ ₹0.52 EURO ₹108.13 ↓ ₹0.62 OIL \$91.97 ↓ \$8.31 POUND ₹124.28 ↓ ₹0.94

Street hits the speed lane as ceasefire revives hope

Sensex has best day in five years, but experts cautious as relief may be temporary

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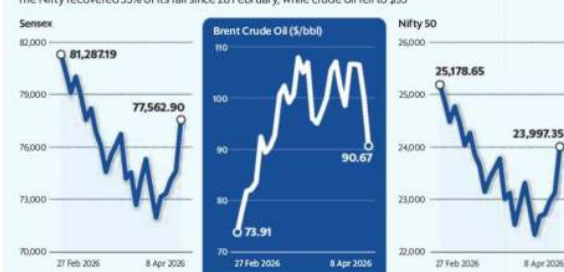
Markets cheered on Wednesday as a fragile peace bloomed in West Asia, following threats of a civilizational wipeout the previous day. While the Sensex had its best day in over five years and the Nifty rose the most in almost a year, experts cautioned that the relief may be temporary, as Tehran has not indicated a definitive pause to its missile and drone strikes.

The Nifty and the Sensex jumped 3.78% and 3.85% to close at 23,997 and 77,562, their highest gains since 12 May 2025, and 1 February 2021, respectively. During the day's session, the Nifty 50 recovered 53% of its fall since 28 February, when the West Asia war broke out. Anxieties cooled, with the India volatility index plunging 20%, its steepest single-day drop since 5 June 2024.

"The announcement of a two-week ceasefire has lifted near-term market sentiment. However, it is premature to conclude that the conflict is fully behind us," said Vinay Jaising, chief investment officer and head of equity advisory at ASR Private Wealth. Sustained improvement in sentiment will

PEACE PARTY

The Nifty recovered 53% of its fall since 28 February, while crude oil fell to \$93



RELIEF RALLY

NIFTY: Sensex up 3.78%, 3.85% to close at 23,997 and 77,562 respectively

DURING the day, the Nifty recovered 53% of its fall since 28 February

VOLATILITY index fell 20%—steepest one-day drop since 5 June 2024

US and Iran have entered into a two-week provisional ceasefire

by US president Donald Trump. The agreement followed 40 days of warfare that sowed widespread destruction in West Asia and disrupted energy supply chains.

The ceasefire is market-positive because it directly reduces the risk of an oil shock to inflation and

ACT Fibernet up for sale; deal likely at \$1 bn valuation

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The owners of ACT Fibernet have decided to sell the company at a valuation of around \$1 billion, three people familiar with the development said, five years after a failed deal to sell the broadband internet provider.

Private equity firms True North and TA Associates have appointed investment banks Nomura and Ambit Capital to find potential buyers for Atria Convergence Technologies Ltd, which provides ACT Fibernet internet services in more than 30 cities, the people cited above said on the condition of anonymity. The two PE firms jointly hold 94.66% in ACT Fibernet, according to CareEdge Ratings.

"The investors have been around for more than a decade," one of the three people said, adding that banks have been appointed for the deal. The banks have sent the information memorandum to prospective buyers and will sign non-disclosure agreements with them soon, the person said.

The sale plan puts the internet provider back on the block. In 2021, Swiss private equity firm Partners Group had



ACT Fibernet was founded in 2000 in Bengaluru. ISTOCKPHOTO

agreed to acquire buy 75% stake in ACT Fibernet from True North and TA Associates at an enterprise value of roughly \$1.2 billion. However, the sale fell through.

"The deal is in initial stages. Large private equity buyout funds and infrastructure-focused investors have been approached," the second person said.

Bengaluru-based ACT Fibernet was founded by Sunder Raju and K Nagaraju in 2000. Since Reliance Jio and Airtel have cornered much of the broadband market in the last five years, the ACT Fibernet buyer must be ready with a detailed plan to scale and monetize the business, the third

DON'T MISS



Cabinet clears ₹41,534 crore fertilizer subsidy for kharif

The Union cabinet on Wednesday approved nutrient-based subsidy (NBS) rates worth about ₹41,533.81 crore for phosphatic and potassic (P&K) fertilizers for the upcoming kharif season, raising support as global prices remain volatile.

Govt raises LPG, natural gas allocation for key industries

The Centre has begun gradually restoring fuel supplies to industry, increasing allocations of LPG and natural gas for key industries, while maintaining the sectoral cap. This comes amid signs of the West Asia conflict easing with a two-week ceasefire.

Adani lawyers reject bribery claims, question SEC ambit

Lawyers for Adani Group chair Gautam Adani and nephew Nagesh Adani in the US on Tuesday filed a motion in a New York federal court to dismiss the securities fraud case brought against them over 15 months ago by the Securities and Exchange Commission.

Wealthy clients drive PMS shift to multi-asset model

India's top wealth managers started looking beyond bets on listed companies to investing models that, in addition to stocks, invest in mutual funds, bonds and commodities. This is also a response to reluctance among investors to pay just for advice.

Retail pullback

The drop in demat additions reflects a cooling primary market, once a major driver of retail participation.



RBI shuns hawkish signal amid war jitters, holds policy rates

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pressure from persistent foreign portfolio investor outflows

DGCA orders upgrades by 2027 to make jets 5G safe

John Grover & Abhishek Law
NEW DELHI

spike in demand. According to estimates, the American re-

2022-23	24.8	-28.3
2023-24	36.9	48.9
2024-25	41.1	11.2
2025-26	32.1	-21.9

Source: CMIE

Market mayhem eats into demat additions in FY26

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After two years of strong expansion, the pace of new demat account additions slowed in FY26, signalling a shift in retail investor behaviour as volatile markets and weaker returns tempered their enthusiasm.

Net demat account additions fell to about 32 million in FY26 from a record 41 million added in FY25, according to data collated from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy. The total number of demat accounts crossed 225 million.

The 22% year-on-year decline in additions of demat accounts—dematerialized or paperless accounts mandated for trading in securities—suggests that the surge in retail participation during the recent bull run is beginning to lose momentum amid a more uncertain global and market environment.

The longer-term trend shows how growth is now normalizing after a sharp post-pandemic surge. New accounts had jumped from 14 million in FY21 to 35 million in FY22, marking a 142% rise, the data showed.

This was followed by a moderation to 25 million in FY23.

The momentum picked up again in FY24 with 37 million new accounts and peaked in FY25, before easing in FY26 as market conditions turned more volatile.

"Markets are currently in a consolidation phase. Whenever markets are in a down-trend and sentiment weakens, retail activity tends to decline. This is a cyclical pattern," said Kranthi Bathini, director of equity strategy at WealthMills Securities. "Seasonal investors typically enter when markets are rising, so periods of negative sentiment lead to slower account additions."

The moderation is also visible in monthly data.

Net additions fell to 2.15 million in March from 2.81 million in February and 3.62 million in January, marking the lowest level of account additions since May 2025.

Month-on-month growth slipped below 1% (to 0.97%), the slowest pace since January 2020.

"The slowdown appears largely cyclical rather than structural," said Harshad Dasani, business head at INVasset.



Reserve Bank of India governor Sanjay Malhotra. BLOOMBERG

The Reserve Bank of India's rate-setting panel kept the policy rate unchanged on Wednesday, while governor Sanjay Malhotra indicated that benchmark rates could remain low for an extended period despite the global uncertainty triggered by the West Asia war.

"We are in a neutral state. Possibility, either way, cannot be ruled out... It is quite possible that even in the short to medium term, we will continue to have low rates," Malhotra said during the monetary policy announcement.

RBI's Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) held the repo rate steady at 5.25% and retained the neutral stance, in line with expectations. A Mint poll of 10 economists and market participants expected the MPC to hold rates while signalling a more cautious policy stance.

Despite rising oil prices and ongoing rupee depreciation pressures, it was notable that signals pointing to a hawkish bias and an imminent rate hike were largely missing, Alexander Hermann Prasad, lead economist at Oxford Economics, said in a note.

After the policy announcement, the yield on the 10-year benchmark government bond fell by 15 basis points to end at 6.89%. The Indian rupee, which has been reeling under

and high oil prices, also appreciated and ended at 92.58 to a dollar on Wednesday against 93.10 in the previous session.

In 2025, the RBI cumulatively cut the repo rate—at which it lends short-term funds to banks—by 125 basis points (bps), with the last cut of 25 bps in December to 5.25%.

The RBI pegged FY26 growth at 7.6% under the new series, higher than the 7.4% estimated in the February policy. However, real GDP growth for FY27 is projected at 6.9% because disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz and elevated energy prices are likely to



US earlier addressed concerns by requiring upgrades. HT

Aviation (DGCA) order dated 19 November 2025. Mint has reviewed a copy of the order.

The required modification or retrofitting must be completed by 31 December 2027, the order said.

India is not alone in facing this challenge. Countries such as the US and those in Europe have faced similar challenges, with regulators proposing deadlines extending to 2029-2032 for full fleet retrofits. But that has also caused a

ulator Federal Aviation Administration (FAA), upgrades will cost around \$4.5 billion for the US fleet alone.

To be sure, the US had earlier addressed 5G interference concerns by requiring upgrades to aircraft radio altimeters, setting a February 2024 deadline. It later said the entire airline fleet had completed these upgrades by September 2023, mitigating immediate risks. However, the country now has plans to expand 5G into a higher spectrum band.

Since the 2022 rollout of 5G in India, telecom operators have had to limit signal strength near airports and follow strict exclusion zones to avoid interference with aircraft systems. According to the November order, the DGCA has also prohibited pilots from conducting automatic landings

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AI giants go on charm offensive to avert public backlash

Bradley Olson & Sam Schechner

Artificial-intelligence companies appear to be organizing around a simple message in the face of rising public anxiety about the negative potential effects of their world-changing technology: We come in peace.

OpenAI this week published a populist wish list of policy proposals that zero in on worries like job replacement and wealth concentration, floating such ideas as a four-day workweek and an AI-invested public-wealth

fund distributed to citizens.

Those proposals come as its rival Anthropic has been signing partnerships and building tools for such sectors as consulting and software, where share prices have been whacked by investor worries that they will be replaced by AI. Anthropic's efforts have

helped push back up shares of tech companies including LegalZoom.com.

Anthropic and OpenAI are each pursuing ventures to help private equity, a big owner of companies in sectors ripe for disruption, with AI transformation. (Those efforts could also yield lucra-



Polls show AI is broadly unpopular, prompting company steps to ease concerns. REUTERS

tive new business customers.)

Call it confidence building for the AI era. The biggest AI companies for a long time amassed marketing mileage and new customers by touting

the nearly godlike transformational potential of their tools. The dangers they talked about felt like far-off science fiction.

Now, as some businesses,

investors and individuals become more concerned about who will be swamped in that transformation, the companies are making a pivot to trying to help manage the downsides.

"We do feel an urgency to this conversation," Chris Leane, OpenAI's chief global affairs officer, told The Wall Street Journal recently.

Some business leaders have started warning that AI disruption might come faster than society can adjust. "There's a real risk artificial intelligence could widen wealth inequality," BlackRock Chief Executive Officer Larry Fink wrote in his annual shareholder letter in March.

An OpenAI spokeswoman said the company is seeking to be proactive in its approach to stoking conversations about AI and its rapid advance. "That means coming to the table with real solutions that are as transformative as the underlying technology," she said.

A handful of recent polls show that the hottest AI labs will have to reassure a wary public. Americans appear profoundly apprehensive about the potential impact of AI on society, with concerns ranging from widespread job losses to broad cybersecurity threats.

A March poll from Quinnipiac University found that

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02 THURSDAY, 9 APRIL 2026 CHENNAI

ECONOMY & POLICY



COLUMN
NARENDRA MODI

RESPOND TO HIS COLUMN AT feedback@livemint.com

TOGETHER, LET US EMPOWER WOMEN, REBUILD SOCIETY

In the coming days, India will be immersed in a festive season—Rongali Bihu in Assam, Maha Vishuva Pana Sankranti in Odisha, Pula Boishukh in West Bengal, Vidu in Kerala, Puthandu in Tamil Nadu, and Baisakhi in Punjab and other parts of North India. Besides, there is the 200th birth anniversary celebrations of Mahatma Phule that will begin on 11 April and Ambedkar Jayanti celebrations on 14 April.

In addition to these special occasions, our nation stands at the threshold of another historic event. On 16 April, Parliament will be convened to discuss and pass an important bill that advances women's reservation. To describe this merely as a legislative exercise would be an understatement. It is a reflection of the aspirations of women across India. It is an affirmation of a principle that has long guided our civilizational ethos, that society progresses when women progress.

Women constitute nearly half of India's population. Their contributions to our nation are vast and invaluable. Today, India is witnessing remarkable achievements by women across every field. From science and technology to entrepreneurship, from sports to the armed forces and from music to the arts, women are at the forefront of India's progress. Over the years, sustained efforts have been made to create an enabling environment for women's empowerment. Greater access to education, improved healthcare, enhanced financial inclusion and better access to basic amenities have strengthened the foundations of women's participation in economic and social life.

Yet, their representation in the world of politics and legislative bodies has not always been commensurate with their role in society. This is particularly unfortunate because when women participate in administration and decision-making, they bring with them experiences and insights that enrich public discourse and improve the quality of governance.

It is imperative that the 2029 Lok Sabha elections and the assembly elections to the various states in the coming times are conducted with women's reservation in place. Over the decades, there have been repeated efforts to provide women with their rightful place in democratic institutions by the previous governments.

Increase in allocation aimed at ensuring fertilizers are available to farmers at affordable prices

Harsh Kumar & Vijay C Ray
NEW DELHI

The Union cabinet on Wednesday approved nutrient-based subsidy (NBS) rates worth about ₹41,533.81 crore for phosphatic and potassic (P&K) fertilizers for the upcoming kharif season, raising support as global prices remain volatile.

The budgetary requirement for the kharif fertilizer subsidy in 2026 is about ₹4,317 crore higher than the ₹3,716.15 crore allocated for kharif 2025. It is also roughly ₹3,582 crore more than the subsidy requirement for the rabi 2025-26 season.

"Under the Nutrient Based Subsidy (NBS) scheme for our 'Amadatas' and farmer brothers, a complete subsidy programme worth ₹41,534 crore has been approved today for farmers for the Kharif season," Union minister Ashwini Vaishnaw told reporters after the cabinet meeting.

The increase in allocation is aimed at ensuring fertilizers remain available to farmers at affordable prices even as international prices of key inputs such as diammonium phosphate (DAP) and muriate of potash (MOP) remain elevated. The war in West Asia has added to supply uncertainties in fertilizer and energy markets.

India is the world's largest importer of diammonium phosphate and a major



The budgetary requirement for the kharif fertilizer subsidy in 2026 is about ₹4,317 crore higher than the ₹3,716.15 crore allocated for kharif 2025.

buyer of other fertilizers. As the second-largest agricultural producer globally, it meets around 60% of its DAP requirement and about 15% of its urea and NPK fertilizer demand through imports.

West Asia meets about 30% of India's urea needs, 30% of di-ammonium phosphate (DAP) demand and 50% of LNG (liquefied natural gas) requirement, which is used for production of fertilizers. The government currently provides 28 grades of phosphatic and potassic fertilizers, including DAP, to farmers at subsidized rates through manufacturers and importers under

the nutrient-based subsidy scheme, which has been in force since April 2010.

"An increase in NBS acts as both a price shield and productivity booster, helping farmers manage costs while sustaining crop output. Higher subsidy means the government bears a larger share of the cost, keeping retail prices of fertilizers like DAP and NPK stable or lower despite global price rises," said Devender Sharma, a farm policy expert.

The subsidy rates approved for the kharif 2026 season will be applicable from 1 April 2026 to 30 September for

phosphatic and potassic fertilizers, including DAP and various NPKS grades. The subsidy will be released to fertilizer companies based on the notified rates to ensure farmers continue to receive fertilizers at reasonable prices.

The government has projected a total fertilizer subsidy of ₹1.7 trillion for FY27, lower than the revised estimate of ₹1.86 trillion for FY26 as it seeks to tighten overall spending.

The Union cabinet also approved the revision of project cost of HPCL Rajasthan Refinery Ltd, from ₹43,129 crore to ₹79,459 crore, along with an additional equity investment of ₹8,962 crore by Hindustan Petroleum Corp. Ltd.

It also cleared two hydroelectric projects in Arunachal Pradesh—the ₹26,069.50 crore Kamala Hydro Electric Project and the ₹4,105.83 crore Kala-I Hydro Electric Project.

Additionally, it approved Jaipur Metro Phase-2, a 41-km north-south corridor with 36 stations, at a total project cost of ₹3,037.66 crore.

The approval for key hydro projects comes at a time when India has emerged as the country with the third largest renewable energy capacity of 250.53 GW after China and the US, Union minister for new and renewable energy Pralhad Joshi on Wednesday said. India had achieved a total non-fossil capacity addition of 55,36 GW in the last financial year (FY26).

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India FY27 growth may decline to 6.6%: WB

Subhash Narayan & Gireesh Chandra Prasad
NEW DELHI

India's economy faces a substantial hit from energy shocks and trade disruptions caused by the West Asia conflict.

The economy is likely to grow at 6.6% in financial year 2026-27 (FY27), slowing from an estimated 7.6% expansion for the year ended March, reflecting headwinds from the West Asia conflict, the World Bank (WB) said in its South Asia Economic Update on Wednesday. This is slightly lower than the 6.9% pace projected by the RBI in its Wednesday's monetary policy statement and the Centre's estimate of 6.8-7.2% made in January before the US and Israel began pummeling Iran on 28 February.

Although last year's reduction in goods and services tax should continue to support consumer demand in the first half of FY27, elevated global energy prices are expected to fuel inflation and constrain households' disposable incomes, the World Bank said.

Government consumption growth may soften to offset higher cooking fuel and fertilizer subsidies, while investment growth may slow, it said.

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witnessing remarkable achievements by women in every field

same spirit of consensus.

This opportunity to ensure women's reservation also resonates deeply with the spirit of our Constitution. The makers of our Constitution envisioned a society where equality is both enshrined and realized in practice. Strengthening women's participation in legislative institutions is an important step towards fulfilling that vision. It reflects our commitment to building a society where every citizen has an equal stake in shaping the nation's destiny.

This is a moment that cannot be deferred any longer. Every delay in advancing women's representation is, in effect, a delay in strengthening the quality and inclusiveness of our democracy. For decades, the need for greater participation of women in legislative institutions has been acknowledged, discussed and reaffirmed. To postpone action now would mean extending an imbalance that we already recognize and have the capacity to correct. At a time when India is moving forward with confidence and purpose, it is essential that our institutions reflect the aspirations of all citizens, especially those who form half our population. Timely action will not only honour long-standing commitments but also ensure that the momentum of progress is sustained. This is truly a historic opportunity to make our democracy more representative, responsive and future-ready.

This moment calls for collective action. It is not about any one government, party or individual. It is about the nation as a whole recognizing the importance of this step and coming together to realize it. It is what we owe to our *Nari Shakti*. That is why the passage of a bill for women's reservation should reflect the broadest possible consensus and be guided by the larger national interest. Such opportunities call upon us to act not for ourselves, but for future generations. They remind us that the true strength of a democracy lies in its ability to evolve and to become more inclusive over time.

The author is the prime minister of India.

Committees were constituted, bill drafts were introduced, but they never saw the light of day. However, The broad consensus has remained that women's representation in legislative bodies has to increase. In September 2023, Parliament passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam with the

Govt raises LPG, gas quota for key sectors

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NEW DELHI

The Centre has begun gradually restoring fuel supplies to industry, increasing allocations of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and natural gas for key industries, while maintaining the sectoral cap. The move comes amid signs of easing of war in West Asia following the announcement of a two-week ceasefire.

The government has raised LPG allocation for pharmaceuticals, food, polymers, agriculture and steel sectors

The government has raised LPG allocation for critical sectors, including pharmaceuticals, food, polymers, agriculture and steel, to 70% of their pre-March 2026 average consumption, according to a letter on Wednesday from the secretary in the ministry of petroleum and natural gas to state chief secretaries.

It has also increased natural gas allocation for the fertilizer industry to 95% of their last six months' average consumption.

In March, the Centre had prioritized LPG supplies for household cooking after about 90% of imports were cut off following the closure of the Strait of Hormuz after strikes by the US and Israel on Iran. Since then, supplies to commercial and industrial users have been gradually restored. India's annual LPG consumption is about 33 million tonnes, of which 60-65% is imported.

The government had earlier allocated up to 70% LPG for commercial supplies to states, including an allocation of up to 10% for promoting piped natural gas (PNG). Sectoral consumption has been capped at 200 tonnes per day, and under the new directive, priority will be given to units that cannot shift from LPG to PNG.

Gas supply to other industrial and commercial sectors, including city gas distribution networks, has also been enhanced by a further 10%, with effect from 6 April.

MSMEs may get relief on NPA norms

Harsh Kumar & Dharendra Kumar
NEW DELHI

The government plans to seek the central bank's support for targeted relief measures to ease financial stress on small businesses hit by the West Asia conflict.

The plan involves regulatory relaxations, including on special mention account (SMA) and non-performing asset (NPA) classification timelines, effectively giving micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) more time before their loans are tagged as stressed or bad, two persons aware of the matter said.

Currently, loans are classified as special mention accounts based on the number of days they remain overdue. These include SMA 0 (1 to 30 days), SMA 1 (31 to 60 days) and SMA 2 (61 to 90 days) as early warning indicators of stress. If the overdue period exceeds 90 days, the loan is classified as a non-performing asset. During the covid-19 pandemic, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had temporarily extended the NPA classification period from 90 days to 180 days.



MSMEs contribute about 30.1% to India's gross domestic product and account for 35.4% of manufacturing output.

The move is part of India's comprehensive plan to roll out a ₹2.5 trillion relief package, including credit guarantees for MSMEs amid

MSME borrowers have increasingly approached lenders seeking relief measures, citing business disruptions

feedback from banks indicating potential stress in their MSME portfolios starting Q1 FY27, the persons cited above said, requesting anonymity.

The current environment, shaped by the West Asia crisis, is creating conditions similar to the covid-19 period, warranting a

closer look at relief measures. This assumes significance given that the MSME sector contributes about 30.1% to India's gross

domestic product and accounts for 35.4% of manufacturing output and nearly 45% of India's merchandise exports.

MSME borrowers have increasingly approached lenders seeking relief measures, citing business disruptions from the West Asia war. Officials of the RBI, the MSME min-

istry, the Department of Financial Services, the Department of Expenditure and industry groups met on Wednesday to discuss the situation.

"Since the current situation is similar to the covid-19 period, the government may consider extending the NPA recognition period and easing Special Mention Account (SMA) norms as part of relief measures for the sector," said the first person.

"There has been substantial feedback from MSME customers through banks, and relaxations in NPA norms are being considered to ease that pressure," the second person said.

Queries emailed to the ministries of finance and MSME, as well as to the RBI remained unanswered till press time.

Experts said there is a need for timely intervention.

"Early policy support is critical in such situations, as delays can allow temporary disruptions to turn into structural damage..." said Rakesh Arrawatia, professor at the Institute of Rural Management Anand.

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For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com)

MINT SHORTS

India buys first Iran oil cargo since 2019 as war curbs supply

State-owned refiner Indian Oil Corp. has purchased a cargo of Iranian oil which would be the country's first such delivery since 2019, said people familiar with the matter, as weeks of West Asia war upends energy trade. India's largest refiner is expected to take delivery of the Middle Eastern volumes this week, they said, without giving any details of the vessel.

Foreign secy Misri arrives in US, to review trade, defence ties

Washington: Foreign secretary Vikram Misri on

Wednesday began a three-day visit to the US to meet senior officials to review bilateral trade and defence relations and discuss global developments, including the West Asia war. The visit offers an opportunity to review the full breadth of the India-US partnership, said India's ambassador to the US Vinay Mohan Kwatra, who welcomed Misri on his arrival late on Tuesday.

FSSAI tightens food safety net; states drive enforcement push

New Delhi: The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) conducted 3,97,000 inspections across food establishments in 2023-24, official sources said on Wednesday. The agency, in collaboration with state authorities, analysed 1,65,747 food samples (up to the third quarter), of which 17.16% were found non-conforming, triggering prompt regulatory action, they said. Legal enforcement also gathered momentum.

MUDRA to empower entrepreneurs: Sitharaman



New Delhi: Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday said the Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana, focused on funding the unfunded, will continue to empower entrepreneurs to make them active participants in the nation's journey to become Viksit Bharat by 2047. She appreciated banks, various financial institutions and stakeholders for bringing the scheme to the common man.

Bangladesh seeks higher diesel, fertilizer supplies from India

New Delhi: Bangladesh foreign minister Khalidur Rahman sought increased diesel and fertilizer supplies from India amid the global supply squeeze, during a meeting with petroleum and natural gas minister Hardeep Singh Puri on Wednesday. India is a major energy exporter to its eastern neighbour.

India puts off steel conference citing West Asia war

New Delhi: The steel ministry has postponed a global steel conference scheduled for 16-17 April in New Delhi, citing disruption to international participation due to the West Asia war, the ministry said. The West Asia war began on 28 February when the US and Israel launched attacks on Iran.

CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS

An 8 April, Page 7 story, 'Hotel chains chase demand, but favour asset-light deals', should have attributed the data on new hotels to HVS Anarack.

The headline of an 8 April, Page 5 story should have said that budget airline SpiceJet has filed a review petition in the Delhi High Court over its dispute with Kalanithi Maran. The error is rectified.

Mint welcomes comments, suggestions or complaints about errors.

Readers can alert the newsroom to any errors in the paper by emailing us, with your full name and address to feedback@livemint.com.

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DEALS, TECH & STARTUPS

THURSDAY, 9 APRIL 2026
CHENNAI

03

MINT SHORTS

Cyient Semiconductors acquires 74% in US's Kinetic Tech for \$85 mn

New Delhi: Cyient Semiconductors has completed the acquisition of a 74% stake in US-based power semiconductor solutions provider Kinetic Technologies for \$85 million. In a regulatory filing, the Hyderabad-based firm said Kinetic Technologies will continue to operate under its current leadership. "Cyient Semiconductors Singapore Pte. Ltd., a wholly owned subsidiary of Cyient Semiconductors Pvt. Ltd., has successfully completed the acquisition of a majority stake of 74% (on fully diluted basis) for a consideration of \$85 million in Kinetic Technologies," it said.

Max Healthcare set to pick up 58% stake in Kalinga Hospital



New Delhi: Max Healthcare Institute Ltd on Wednesday said it has entered into a share purchase agreement to acquire a controlling stake of 58.4% in Kalinga Hospital from Hospital Corp. of Orissa Inc. at an equity value of ₹300

A viral now revives an untold story of TikTok-era creators

Before its ban, TikTok had 200 mn Indian users, opening social media to small-town creators

Pratishtha Baga
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MUMBAI

A creator's fluent English, a swirl of opinions around urban cues and a rural backdrop—an unlikely mix that has set the internet abuzz. It centres on West Bengal's East Midnapore-based Pujari Pradhan (@lifeforpuja), whose videos span cinema, culture, feminism and cooking. Critics questioned her authenticity, pointing to a perceived mismatch between her content and background. But if anything, the row has turned the spotlight back on creators from small towns and villages—those who dominated social media during the TikTok era with their raw, regional appeal.

Beyond one creator, the episode



"What we offered by launching Moj wasn't a replacement. It was continuity. While several platforms that rushed in to fill that void have since shut shop or shrunk considerably, we have stayed the course," said Ankush Sachdeva, CEO and co-founder of short video platforms ShareChat, Moj and Quick TV. "Influencers barely earning any thing before June 2020, now take home an average of ₹25,000 a month. More established creators get 6-7 brand campaigns, translating into over ₹50,000 a month," he added.

Some creators chose to ditch short-form content for long-form YouTube videos to skip stiff competition. "When TikTok got banned, most creators were looking for an easy transition into a similar short-form app... However, we decided to get into long-format on YouTube," said Jaipur-based Suraj Pal

Kluisz now Nava, raises \$21.7 mn for cloud push

Rwit Ghosh
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BENGALURU

Private cloud computing startup Kluisz has rebranded as Nava and raised \$21.7 million (about US\$ crore) in a Series A funding round led by Greenoaks Capital, as investors bet on rising demand for artificial intelligence (AI) computing infrastructure. Existing investors RTP Global and Unicorn India Ventures also participated.

"Our ambitions now entails building a full stack new cloud platform," said Abhinav Sinha, co-founder and chief executive at Nava, in an interview. "We are going to build AI data centres and GPU compute."

The moves mark a broader pivot for the company, from offering private-cloud services for enterprises to positioning

crore including control premium. Operating since 1997, the 250-bed, NABH accredited Kalinga Hospital offers super specialty services for neuro, cardio, ortho, gastro, med onco and renal sciences. **PTI**

ClayCo gets ₹34.6 cr in Series A led by Twenty-Nine Capital Partners

New Delhi: ClayCo has raised ₹34.59 crore, announcing the closure of its Series A funding. The startup will use the fund to accelerate product development, expand into new categories, and strengthen its working capital, said ClayCo in a statement. The round was led by Twenty-Nine Capital Partners Ventures, with participation from ICMG Global Ventures II, Singapore. **PTI**

Indian tech startups' funding dips 18% to \$11.7 billion in FY26: Tracxn

New Delhi: Indian technology startups' total fundraising declined by 18% to \$11.7 billion in FY26, market intelligence firm Tracxn said on Wednesday. Technology startups had raised \$14.3 billion in FY25. "India's startups raised \$11.7 billion in FY2025-26, marking an 18% decline from \$14.3 billion in FY25, but a 20% increase compared to \$9.7 billion in FY24," Tracxn's India Tech Annual Funding Report 2026 said. India ranked as fourth-highest funded country globally in FY26, behind the US, UK, and China. **PTI**

offers cues on the highs and lows of virality in the creator economy, especially in the hinterland.

When Musically rebranded as TikTok in 2018, its easy-to-use format and dancing drew millions into content creation. Challenges and trends amplified the 'fomo'—fear of missing out. TikTok broadened access to social media and enabled creators from diverse backgrounds, including tier-2, -3 and -4 cities, to go viral, earn not just eyeballs but livelihoods. TikTok reportedly had 200 million India users before the ban.

Then came India's ban in 2020, citing the app's Chinese origins as a national security threat. Users went scrambling for alternatives. YouTube and Instagram, cashed in, releasing short-format features within a couple of months, offering alternatives.

A shift wasn't easy. "After the ban, we moved to Snack Video, but even that got banned in two months. We then shifted to stable platforms Instagram and YouTube, but it was difficult to

A viral controversy around West Bengal creator Pujarini Pradhan has reignited debate over authenticity and identity in India's creator economy. **MENT**

navigate," said Sanatan Mahato, a martial artist-turned-dancer from Kusmat and village near Dhanbad, whose dance videos with his sister Savitri Devi went viral. "We didn't understand the interface, the algorithm. Everyone was racing for the top spot...It never matched

focused on audience growth, he said. What TikTok gave him was popularity. "People still recognize us as the dancing siblings, even though now I make vlogs with my wife on other platforms," Mahato said. His sister, now married and living in Maharashtra, separately

HINTERLAND CREATORS

AFTER TikTok's ban, creators shifted to platforms such as YouTube, Instagram, Moj and ShareChat.

SOME creators moved to long-form content, building audiences via vlogs, ad-revenue models.

DESPITE growth in creator economy, many influencers struggled to sustain their livelihoods.

TODAY, with nearly 60 lakh creators in India, only about 5,000 receive regular brand deals.

the craze and simplicity of TikTok, even though we retained followers."

He has 20.6 lakh subscribers on his YouTube account. Dancer Sanatan and 11 lakh on Instagram. Mahato never earned from content on any of these apps, as he was unsure of the proposed brands' authenticity, so he just

creates videos with her family.

Content apps such as Moj and ShareChat, popular in tier-2 and -3 cities and towns, stepped in to absorb stranded TikTok stars at the time. They offered stable income from short-form format akin to TikTok, while others experimented with revenues and brand deals.

Singh, who posts vlogs with his partner Yashi Tank on a joint account @sushvlogs that has 73.5 lakh subscribers.

"The transition wasn't easy because it was more time-consuming, especially for editing. In first six months, we only managed to put out one video a week," Singh said. "But after a few of went viral and we got the hang of it, we started posting daily and even ad revenues came in by then."

Agencies, a bridge between creators and brands, saw this from a bird's-eye view. "About 70% of creators lost livelihoods after TikTok, as they were highly dependent on the app, where they had built communities of millions of followers in five years, but they were unable to transition to other platforms," said Gautam Madhavan, founder of Xley AI, a creator marketplace. "With the creator economy is sitting at about 60 lakh creators, the agency ecosystem is unable to give business to all of them. Only about 5,000 get regular brand deals."

For an extended version of the story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

itself as a "neocloud" platform, providing GPU-based infrastructure for artificial intelligence workloads.

Demand for AI computing capacity is driving the emergence of several providers in India, with Nava, NeevCloud, NxtGen, E2E Networks, and data-centre provider Yotta Data Services are competing for business in a relatively nascent segment. They also face competition from global players like Nasdaq-listed CoreWeave and Lambda.

The round marks its second capital raise, coming just eight months after its \$9.6 million seed round last July—the largest seed round for an AI firm at the time. Neocloud platforms offer GPU-as-a-service infrastructure for AI inference, machine learning and other compute-intensive workloads.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

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BSE Sensex		Nifty 50		Nifty 500		Nifty Next 50		Nifty 100		BSE 150 MidCap		BSE 250 SmallCap	
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77,635.54	77,042.15	24,025.15	23,828.50	22,159.50	21,952.40	66,247.25	65,295.05	24,690.30	24,470.30	15,365.16	15,195.12	6,152.40	6,058.47

Paint cos get relief, but will it last?

Market mayhem eats into demat

Shares of Asian Paints Ltd, Berger Paints India Ltd and Kansai Nerolac Paints Ltd rallied 1.5-6% on Wednesday as crude oil prices eased. After the news of a two-week ceasefire in the West Asia war, Brent crude slipped to \$92.46 a barrel from a closing high of \$107.9 a barrel on 18 March.

Crude derivatives like solvents, resins and binders comprise 40% of the raw material basket for paint firms, so higher oil prices weigh on gross margins. To counter inflation in crude-oil-linked input costs, listed paintmakers recently undertook calibrated price increases.

Decorative paints giant Asian Paints announced a 6-8% price hike in two phases. In the first phase, prices in decorative categories of emulsions, enamels, and primers, will rise from 10 April, a dealers' channel check by Motilal Oswal Financial Services showed. The second phase will begin from 21 April, covering waterproofing, adhesives, and wood

Biting the bullet

Despite competitive pressures, paint companies have opted for price hikes to tackle input cost inflation.

Company	Asian Paints	Berger Paints	Kansai Nerolac	Indigo Paints
Price hikes	6-8%	2-3%	5-10%	2-3%

Source: Motilal Oswal Financial Services

Cooling down

Brent crude price eased on Wednesday, after a two-week ceasefire of the West Asia war was announced.

Brent crude (in \$/barrel)



Source: Bloomberg

finishes. Rival Berger Paints India has implemented its first phase, hiking prices by 3% from 25 March, and will increase prices another 5-10% from 10 April, said the Motilal report on 2 April. Indigo Paints and Kansai Nerolac have also hiked prices. Trade discounts, given on the product's listed price to encourage bulk buy-

ing, have also been cut. Benign costs and increased competition over the past two to three years had led to a massive increase in trade discounts.

The benefit of price hikes on margins and realizations should reflect in Q4FY27. But this may not rekindle investor confidence. Brent crude is still elevated compared to \$71.4 a bar-

rel on 26 February, before the war broke out. "Even if the Middle East crisis is resolved in the next two to three months, supply-chain impacts may persist through H1FY27," ICICI Securities said on 3 April. It expects paint companies to lower volume growth guidance due to these hikes and their potential impact on demand for projects and industrial coatings.

Conversely, revenue growth guidance may be revised upward. Asian Paints guided for 9-10% volume growth and 5-6% revenue growth in the medium term, with Ebitda margin guidance of 18-20%. Berger projects 12-13% volume growth, 7-8% value growth, and an Ebitda margin of 15-17%. Kansai guided for Ebitda margin of 12-13%.

Demand is precarious and a new threat may be emerging. Weather forecasting agency Skymet has predicted below-normal monsoon rainfall this year amid an El Niño risk. Farm output could be hit thereby

hurting rural consumption. If this plays out, it exposes paint stocks to de-rating risks, given their rural India exposure. In its Q3FY26 earnings call, Asian Paints management had said rural demand outperformed urban, supported by good monsoons and improved sentiment.

Meanwhile, channel restocking by dealers in March, before price hikes, should buoy Q4FY26 performance. Paint firms typically have 30-45 days of raw material and finished goods inventory, which cushions the impact of rising input costs, said Nuvama Research. So, it expects margin impact to be limited in Q4FY26, with Berger and Asian Paints likely

to report 9-10% volume growth. Asian Paints and Berger shares are down 17% and 18%, respectively, so far in 2026, and trade at 40 and 36 times estimated FY28 earnings, based on Bloomberg data. With significant growth levers missing, these valuations are unattractive.

TO counter inflation in crude-oil-linked input costs, listed paintmakers recently increased prices

BEATING BLUES
CRUDE derivatives like solvents, resins comprise 40% of the raw material basket for paint companies

additions in FY26

FROM PAGE 1

PMS. "Elevated volatility, muted secondary market returns and disappointing IPO outcomes have reduced the quick-gain appeal that drove retail participation in recent years."

He said the broader structural drivers remain intact. "Digital access, lower costs and rising awareness continue to support long-term growth. What has changed is behaviour—investors are becoming more selective and disciplined."

The moderation in demat additions comes against the backdrop of a challenging year for equities.

The benchmark indices posted their weakest performance in six years in FY26, with the Nifty 50 declining 5.1% and the Sensex falling 7.1%.

The broader markets had a mixed trend. The Nifty Midcap 150 managed a modest gain of 1.6%, supported by selective buying, while the Smallcap 250 declined almost 5.4%, reflecting pressure in riskier segments.

Global factors contributed to the volatility. US tariff actions, geopolitical tensions in West Asia and persistent foreign portfolio investor outflow at over US\$1 trillion during the year kept the markets on edge and triggered intermittent corrections.

The slowdown in demat additions mirrors a cooling in primary market activity, which had been a key driver of retail participation in recent years.

India's market for initial public offerings had expanded rapidly, with fun-



Indices performed their weakest in 6 years. ISTOCKPHOTO

draising increasing from ₹20,350 crore in FY20 to ₹1.1 trillion in FY22 and peaking in the subsequent years. However, the momentum has softened.

A Mint analysis shows that the share of mainboard IPOs receiving strong retail subscription—defined as more than 10 times demand for shares offered—declined to 39.4% in FY26 from 58.2% in FY25 and 52.6% in FY24.

This reflects a clear shift towards more selective participation.

"The moderation looks more like a pause than a reversal," Dasani said. "However, FY27 may not see a sharp rebound unless

market stability improves and IPO outcomes strengthen."

Growth is likely to continue at a measured pace, driven more by informed participation than speculative enthusiasm.

Bathini of WealthMills echoed a similar view on the outlook.

"Once market sentiment improves, the pace of new investor additions will pick up again. India still has significant headroom for growth as equity penetration remains low," he said.

Godrej Consumer's margin may hold firm despite inflation

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Since the West Asia war began, Godrej Consumer Products Ltd's (GCPCL) shares had dropped 18% till Monday when it announced its Q4FY26 business update. The shares have gained about 7% in the past two trading sessions.

Margin pressures, given the higher palm oil price, seem to be worrying investors. The management's outlook on margin should bring comfort. GCPCL said with Brent crude prices at \$100-110 per barrel and palm oil at Malaysian

Ringgit 4,500-4,800 per tonne, it expects a 6-9% cost hit going into FY27. The firm will offset this via price hikes, cost savings, and media optimization.

GCPCL believes elevated costs augur well for formalization of demand in select categories. So, "even if costs remain at these levels, we should be broadly in line with our original bottom-line plans for FY27 while stepping up revenue growth," said GCPCL. Standalone Q4FY26 Ebitda margin is expected to sustain within its normative range (24-26%). Excluding soaps, Q4 volume growth continues in

Staying put

Godrej Consumer is expected to sustain its Ebitda margin in Q4FY26 despite inflationary pressures.



Source: Company, Nomura

double-digits. Nomura Research expects home-care segment (45% of FY25 India sales) sales growth of close to

double-digits with household insecticides growing in high single-digit, and the new growth business growing over

15%. Nomura expects personal care category to show mid-single-digit growth with benefits of soaps restocking fading in Q4, while hair colours and deo/grow in high-single-digits. The Indonesia business is stabilizing, while GAIUM (Africa, US, Middle East) segment continues to deliver double-digit growth. These markets are skewed toward faster growth categories like hair care and household insecticides. Q4FY26 consolidated revenue is seen rising in almost double-digit year-on-year, a tad better than expectations. GCPCL's SMFY26 consolidated revenue grew 7.6%.

Q4 Ebitda growth should be in line with revenue growth.

GCPCL is set to benefit from enhanced contribution from high-growth categories, better mix, and firm realizations aided by price hikes. This positions it for revenue growth in FY27, despite cost woes. Investors seem to be factoring the optimism adequately with the stock trading at 38 times FY28 estimated earnings, as per Bloomberg. Any sharper-than-expected spike in input costs or delay in price hikes could lead to temporary margin compression, given the lag between cost inflation and price hikes.

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Wealthy clients drive PMS multi-asset shift NSE begins IPO prep, meets 20 bankers

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MUMBAI

India's top wealth managers have started looking beyond bets on listed companies to investing models that, in addition to stocks, invest in mutual funds, bonds, and commodities.

In doing so, not only are they spreading out risk and limiting downside on returns, they are also responding to reluctance among investors to pay just for advice on which funds to buy or sell in a falling market.

The so-called multi-asset model has seen steady traction in recent years, according to industry insiders. While data at the industry-wide level is not available, Mint interviewed senior executives at large wealth management companies and portfolio management services, or PMS, firms and analyzed their portfolios to capture the trend.

Some quick background: a wealth manager, typically, earns revenue in two ways. Under the distribution model, it sells financial products and earns commissions or trail fees from an asset management company, nothing from the client. Under the advisory model, it gives independent advice and bills the client.

As markets shed value rapidly and returns dry up, there is waning appetite among investors for advisory-led models and more demand for a multi-asset structure comprising MFs, bonds, and commodities. Most PMS firms have stocks as their underlying assets.

"Over the past three-four



As markets shed value rapidly and returns dry up, there is waning appetite among investors for advisory-led models. ISTOCKPHOTO

years, some clients have gravitated towards direct plans due to cost considerations. However, their need for proper fund advisory has led to wealth managers offering structured, fund-of-funds-like portfolios, especially for large clients with ₹25-40 crore portfolio," said Jayesh Faria, director, regional head, Motilal Oswal Private Wealth.

At 360 ONE Wealth Management, the biggest listed wealth management company in India, fund assets under multi-asset strategy grew 2.1x to ₹62,212 crore between FY23 and FY25.

Dezerv Investments, the largest PMS with 100% multi-asset structure, increased its number of clients to 5,589 in December 2025 from 975 two years before with assets surging fourfold to ₹1,244 crore over the same period, according to

The so-called multi-asset model has seen steady traction in recent years, according to industry insiders

HNs, especially those with ultra portfolios above ₹100 crore, there is a strong preference for structured portfolio management as managing large assets in an ad hoc manner becomes impractical," said Chatterjee. The advisory model has struggled to gain traction in India due to higher compliance requirements, often account-

ing for 15% to 20% of costs and client reluctance to pay out-of-pocket fees.

As of March 2025, there were only 93 investment advisors, according to data from markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India. In contrast, there are some 178,000 mutual fund distributors in the country.

With guidelines for registered investment advisers (RIA) becoming more stringent and fee caps coming into play, the PMS route where underlying assets are mutual funds, bonds, and commodities, has emerged as a more scalable alternative, said Ferroz Azeem, joint CEO at Anand Rathi Wealth. It provides greater flexibility in terms of fee structures and allows firms to operate within a broader commercial framework, he added.

"The RIA model separates advice from execution. The advisor recommends, but the client decides whether and when to buy. If the client is busy or traveling, opportunities slip," said Vaibhav Porwal, co-founder, Dezerv. A PMS firm offering a multi-asset model. "Discretionary PMS instead of pure advisory model eliminates this entirely where the rebalancing or creating a position can be done immediately."

In discretionary PMS, all the investment calls are taken by the fund manager without seeking prior approval from the investor. In non-discretionary PMS, even though the fund manager takes the calls, the end decision rests with the client.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

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The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) has begun preparations for its initial public offering (IPO), meeting all 20 of its investment bankers earlier this week to start drafting the offer document and outline a tentative timeline for the listing, three people aware of the matter told Mint.

The IPO bankers and the exchange started the drafting process for the offer document and chalked out a rough timeline for the listing, one of the people cited above said on the condition of anonymity.

"NSE met all 20 bankers together for the first time, where everyone agreed to a tentative timeline for the IPO," this person said, adding that the process will begin with the identification of risks and the preparation of required disclosures, work on which is likely to begin this week.

The exchange will contact all retail shareholders who wish to participate in the share sale by the end of April, a second person aware of the discussions said, wishing not to be named discussing private deliberations.

The exchange's registrar had already asked retail shareholders late last month to express their interest in the IPO.

"The exact date of the filing of the DRHP with Sebi is currently unknown. Accordingly, only such equity shares which have been held continuously since 15 June 2025 (the cut-off



The IPO bankers and NSE have started the drafting process. MINT

date) will be eligible to be sold in the Offer for Sale," the registrar's letter to retail investors read, a copy of which has been reviewed by Mint.

"Once these retail investors express their interests, the bankers will have a three-week period to review the outreach. During this time, the exchange will also formalise institutional participants for the offer-for-sale portion," the second person explained.

Once the sellers and the stake they are paring are fixed by the end of May, the exchange will determine the valuation for the offering, the third person explained. "Right now, everyone agrees that it is too early to discuss valuations," this person added.

If all goes according to plan and everyone is on the same page about the valuation, the exchange is eyeing to file draft

papers with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) by June or early July, the second person added.

"Pursuant to the NOC issued by Sebi, the board approved an initial public offering of the Company through an offer for sale on 6 February 2026. No further comments at this stage," NSE said in response to Mint's queries.

The move follows efforts by the exchange to resolve regulatory matters that previously stalled the listing.

The bourse's IPO is likely to be among India's largest offerings with a potential 4-4.5% stake sale. Based on unlisted share prices, this could make the offer worth \$1.5 billion to \$2.5 billion, or approximately ₹23,000 crore.

The NSE IPO is part of a pipeline of large public offerings expected in 2026, including planned listings by Reliance's Jio Platforms, India's largest asset manager SBI Funds, and e-commerce operator Flipkart.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.



Electric car makers appeal to Karnataka to review new tax

Firms say a 5-10% lifetime tax on EVs could impact the investment outlook for the industry

Manas Pimpalkhure & Ayaan Karik
NEW DELHI

Major electric car makers, including JSW MG Motor India, Tata Motors, Mahindra & Mahindra, Hyundai Motor India, and Kia India, have written to Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah, urging the state to reconsider a new 5-10% lifetime tax on electric vehicles (EVs), according to correspondence reviewed by *Mint* and a person familiar with the matter.

The companies have sought a meeting with Siddaramaiah, warning that the move could affect air pollution goals, oil imports, energy security and the investment outlook for India's EV industry.

Mint reported on 31 March that Karnataka had reversed its earlier EV road tax waiver, a step that risks slowing adoption in one of India's key EV markets. In 2025, the state accounted for 12% of the country's electric car sales, with more than 21,000 units sold and passenger vehicle penetration of 6.4%, compared with 4% nationally.

"The objective of this engagement is to share industry perspectives on the recent revisions in road tax applicable to electric passenger vehicles in Karnataka. While we fully appreciate the state's fiscal considerations, we would like to submit that policy signals of this nature may have a bearing on the reduction in air pollution, crude oil import and energy security, consumer sentiment and investment outlook, particularly at a time when the EV ecosystem is at a critical growth juncture," the correspondence said.

Queries e-mailed to the Karnataka government, JSW MG Motor India, Tata Motors, Mahindra & Mahindra, Hyundai Motor India, and Kia India



Karnataka's decision to impose the 5-10% lifetime tax on electric vehicles comes roughly seven months after the Centre cut the GST on fuel-based vehicles.

remained unanswered till press time.

A bill passed last month in the Karnataka assembly imposes a 5-10% tax on EVs based on their registration price, widening the gap with cheaper internal

a higher lifetime registration tax of 13-18% of a vehicle's cost under the amended law.

Electric cars still generally cost ₹2-4 lakh more than comparable petrol or

(GST) on ICE cars from 28% to 18%, based on engine size. This move reduced the tax gap between EVs and ICE cars from 23% to 13%. According to Deloitte's Global Consumer Study 2026, about one-third of Indian consumers cited high prices as a key barrier to EV adoption. Karnataka's move also comes as states such as Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Delhi waive EV road taxes to promote adoption.

The correspondence also said Karnataka's EV adoption has been built on policy consistency and forward-looking incentives, and that "sustaining this momentum will be crucial for achieving state environmental goals and also for reinforcing its position as a preferred destination for future investments in EV value chain".

None of the automakers has electric car manufacturing facilities in the state, though Tata Motors operates an electric commercial vehicle plant in Dhawad.

Experts note that new technologies need sustained policy support to scale. "New technologies require sustained policy support in their early years to reach scale. However, as markets mature, a calibrated transition becomes necessary," said Amit Bhatt, India managing director of the International Council on Clean Transportation, a global think-tank working on clean mobility.

"For instance, Norway introduced full road taxation on EVs in 2022, when their share in new car sales had crossed 80%. In Karnataka's case, it is important to assess whether EV uptake has reached a critical level before introducing taxation. The key will be to ensure that any transition is gradual and does not disrupt the momentum of EV adoption," Bhatt added.

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SPEED BREAKER

THE companies have sought a meeting with the Karnataka CM to resolve the issue

KARNATAKA'S reversal of EV road tax waiver risks slowing one of India's key EV markets

IN 2025, Karnataka accounted for 12% of all the electric cars that were sold across the country

THE state had sold over 21,000 units in 2025 and had 6.4% PV penetration, against 4% nationally

combustion engine (ICE) vehicles.

The move partly negates Karnataka's 2025 clean mobility policy, which waived road and registration taxes for EVs priced under ₹25 lakh.

ICE vehicles in Karnataka will attract

diesel models, though tax waivers in several states have helped narrow the gap.

The state's decision comes roughly seven months after the Union government cut the goods and services tax

Neo plots ₹2,000-crore realty debut

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At a time when global geopolitical tensions are making foreign investors cautious, Neo Alternative Asset Managers is doubling down on domestic credit with plans to raise ₹1,500-2,000 crore for its maiden real estate fund, its managing director Kaushik Desai told *Mint* in an interview. The category-II alternative investment fund (AIF) will largely offer credit to residential real estate developers across tier II cities, he said.

Earlier this week, Neo Alternative Asset Managers said it had ventured into real estate, bringing on board Kaushik Desai, Vinit Prabhuganekar, and Vimal Jangla, the former senior leadership team at Walton Street India, to anchor its real estate investment platform.

The three bring with them more than two decades of experience in real estate investing, asset management, and structured financing. During their tenure at Walton Street India, the team man-



Kaushik Desai, MD, Neo Alternative Asset Managers.

aged and advised on more than 100 projects, successfully exiting a major portion of those investments with strong internal rates of return (IRR).

The alternatives arm of Neo Group operates across private equity, private credit, and infrastructure (real assets). Neo Group, a wealth and asset management firm based in Mumbai, is backed by Peak XV Partners, Japan's MUFG, New York's Euclidean Capital, and TVS Group. It has

₹1 trillion of assets under management (AUM).

"We are still finalizing the strategy of the first real estate fund. We plan to launch it this year after the necessary approvals. The fund's aim is to offer experienced asset management and deliver consistent risk-adjusted returns to investors," Desai told *Mint*.

AIFs have significantly transformed real estate financing in India, offering a crucial lifeline to projects through funding and unlocking new

opportunities for developers.

As per property advisory Anarock Group's estimates last year, the real estate sector accounted for the largest share (15%) of cumulative net AIF investments, with ₹73,903 crore invested in real estate out of ₹5,066 trillion across sectors, as of December 2025.

Neo is entering the real estate market to address a widening credit gap, as traditional banks remain wary of funding land acquisitions and early-stage construction for mid-sized players. While developers are hungry for expansion capital, Desai noted that the demand is being met by a healthy supply of private capital, which has stepped in where institutional lending has tightened. "The markets are getting slower due to the geopolitical environment. We will be raising capital for the fund from domestic investors. Though investors are cautious today, Neo has a good track record," he said.

Within real estate, Neo will start with a residential-focused fund, after which it plans to invest in logistics, commercial, and special-situation assets.

For an extended version of the story, go to livenint.com

True North, TA revive plan to sell ACT Fibernet in \$1 bn deal

FROM PAGE 1

person said.

A Nomura spokesperson declined to comment. Queries e-mailed to True North, TA Associates and Amhul Capital remained unanswered.

According to Capgemini rating, the wired broadband segment expanded at a strong compounded annual growth rate of about 19% in three years ending fiscal year 2025 (FY25), supported by rising digital consumption, enterprise digitalization, and government initiatives such as BharatNet. However, there is heightened competition from telecom service providers, it added.

"The industry recorded a growth of 3% in FY25 and 9% in 9MFY26. Despite the competition from telcos, and alternative technologies, ACT recorded net subscriber additions of 2.2% in FY25 and 3.3% in 9MFY26, per Telecom Regulatory Authority of India data. The company remains the largest non-telco internet service provider in India," the report said.

Although market share



ACT's operating income grew 4% in FY25.

moderated slightly to 5.2% as of 31 December, 2025 (from 5.5% as of 31 March, 2025), ACT continues to differentiate itself through high network uptime, superior service quality, and value-added offerings such as technology upgrades and bundled over-the-top (OTT) services, supporting customer retention and growth, it said.

As per the Capgemini release, ACT's operating income grew 4% to reach ₹2,204 crore in FY25. "Revenue growth remained measured in FY25 due to modest growth in subscribers and an increasing aver-

age revenue per user (ARPU), considering intense competition from major telcos. Operating profitability decreased to 34.7% in FY25 from 37.07% in FY24, mainly due to distribution expenses aimed at customer retention and acquisition. Operating profitability remains healthy at 35.35% for 9MFY26. The entity's ability to maintain operating profitability will remain a key credit monitorable," it said.

In June 2025 research report, India Brand Equity Foundation or IBEF said that India's fixed communication services market is set for steady growth, with revenue projected to rise from ₹1,09,632 crore (₹12.8 billion) in 2024 to ₹1,43,323 crore (₹16.5 billion) in 2029, growing at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 5.2%.

"Fibre optic connections, which accounted for the majority of new broadband subscriptions, are expected to comprise 94% of India's total broadband lines by 2029, aided by government and private investment in fibre-to-the-home (FTTH) infrastructure," it said.

SILA raises \$100 mn to fund its plans for expansion

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Business services platform SILA has raised \$100 million from private equity firm Permira to accelerate its expansion, underscoring growing global investor interest in India's services ecosystem.

The capital will help SILA strengthen its technology capabilities, expand into adjacent service lines and pursue growth opportunities across India, the companies said in a statement on Wednesday.

The investment reflects growing optimism among global institutional investors around India's business services spanning commercial, industrial, residential, and retail assets—representing what investors see as a compelling opportunity.

Valued at over \$25 billion in 2024, the business software and services market is projected to grow at a 16% CAGR, reaching roughly \$60 billion by 2030, as per online reports. SILA will leverage Permira's four decades of experience for its expansion across India through strengthening its tech capabilities, expanding adjacent service lines and pursuing growth opportunities.

"India is creating a new generation of globally relevant, tech-enabled services companies—and SILA is among the most compelling we've seen,"

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Prestige Estates hits pre-sales mark of ₹30,000 cr in FY26

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Prestige Estates Projects Ltd clocked its highest annual pre-sales of ₹30,024 crore in FY26, up 76%, on account of sustained momentum throughout the year.

The Bengaluru-based developer recorded ₹7,697 crore of pre-sales in the January-March quarter alone. Bookings remained consistent across new project launches and existing inventory, reflecting resilient demand, Prestige Estates said in a regulatory filing. Bengaluru, the National Capital Region, Mumbai, Hyderabad and Chennai contributed to the pre-sales.

"Demand across our key markets has remained encouraging, and our focus on quality, location, and timely execution continues to resonate well with customers," Prestige chairman and managing director, Irfan Razack said in the filing on Tuesday. "With a robust pipeline of upcoming



Irfan Razack, chairman and managing director, Prestige Estates Projects.

launches across geographies, we are optimistic about sustaining this momentum."

Prestige had missed its sales target in FY25 as bookings declined 19% to ₹17,023 crore, below the guided ₹24,000 crore, mainly due to the lack of adequate new project launches on account of approval delays.

Lodha Developers Ltd said on Tuesday it missed its FY26 pre-sales guidance of ₹21,000

crore due to the impact of the Iran war. Lodha Developers' bookings rose to ₹20,530 crore in FY26 from ₹17,630 crore in the previous year.

India's top four real estate developers—Godrej Properties Ltd, Lodha Developers, DLF Ltd and Prestige Estates Projects—collectively aim to cross ₹1 trillion in residential sales in FY26, as per their sales guidance, marking the strongest year yet for branded companies.

Godrej Properties, which set a booking guidance of ₹32,500 crore for FY26, is yet to announce its sales numbers.

Crissil Ratings said in March that the residential real estate sector appears to have entered a phase of calibrated growth after a strong post-pandemic surge that enabled it to clock a compounded annual growth rate of 26% in FY22-25. Steady operating performance underpinned by healthy collections has translated into controlled debt levels, supporting the credit profiles of developers, the rating company noted.

Foreign audiences are getting hooked to Indian video, audio content

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Indian audio and video content, usually considered a draw for domestic audiences and specific diasporic markets, is now finding a home in unusual export destinations. Saudi Arabia, Egypt, and the

appears to be driven by cultural alignment. Indian storytelling—especially emotion-led narratives, family dynamics and mythology—tends to resonate strongly with audiences in these regions. To build on this trend, platforms are rethinking storytelling, distribution and pricing in a more nuanced and mar-



infrastructure, affordable smartphones and wider OTT access, has played a significant role in accelerating this shift.

Compared to the saturated Western markets, the competitive intensity is lower, engagement with culturally aligned content is

emotionally rich narratives, high-stakes character arcs and mythology-inspired worlds resonate deeply with audiences beyond the traditional diaspora.

One of its Indian programmes, *Mahagatha*, has been reimagined as *Forged Through*

and morality, combined with growing openness among audiences in the US and Europe to explore fresh, global narratives beyond their traditional content ecosystems. Additionally, serialized storytelling formats, especially in audio, are enabling deeper engagement and long-term audience retention, "Gangwar

OFFSHORE AUDIENCE

SAUDI Arabia, Egypt, and the Philippines have taken a liking to

empires are among the countries where Indian content is popular, according to the Content Trends Report launched recently at the Content India Summit 2026, organized by Dish TV.

Experts said this demand is not dispersed-led, unlike more established markets such as the US or the UK. Instead, it

"We're seeing a noticeable rise in non-traditional markets emerging as strong consumers of Indian content—particularly Southeast Asia including Indonesia, Thailand and Vietnam, the Middle East beyond the UAE, parts of Africa such as Nigeria and Kenya, and regions within Eastern Europe

The increased availability of dubbed and subtitled content, among other things, has improved reach of Indian content.

or CIS (Commonwealth of Independent States)," said Nitin Burman, chief revenue officer, Balaji Telefilms.

These emerging markets

represent a high-growth frontier, Burman added. The increased availability of dubbed and subtitled content, along with improving digital

higher, and OTT penetration still has a long runway.

Lalit Gangwar, senior vice-president and head of US at Pocket FM, an audio streaming platform, said stories rooted in Indian storytelling traditions with

INDIAN storytelling tends to resonate strongly with audiences in these regions

"This shift is largely driven by the universality of themes such as ambition, love, power

Ujjwal Mahajan, co-founder of Chuphal, a platform specializing in Punjabi, Haryanvi and Bhojpuri content, called it one of the fastest-rising markets and noted that the company sees subscribers in Kenya and Ethiopia as well.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

partner and co-CEO at Permira. "SLA has built a leading market position, supported by deep client relationships, a strong culture, disciplined execution and a focus on tech," Permira's head of Asia Siddharth Narayan added.

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RBI debuts core inflation forecast, pegs FY27 at 4.4%

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The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday announced its first-ever projection for core inflation—price rises excluding food and energy—with governor Sanjay Malhotra saying the move came in response to demand from some quarters.

"We are doing this for the first time as has been the demand from some quarters and going forward, we shall continue giving our projections for core inflation," he said.

RBI projected core inflation at 4.4% for FY27. Excluding precious metals, core inflation is even lower, indicating that underlying inflation pressures are likely to remain contained.

Malhotra said headline inflation remained below target in January-February, at 2.7% and 3.2%, respectively, with the food group recording inflation as against a deflation in previous four months. He said inflation in fuel items was modest. Core inflation was at 3.7% and underlying price pressures benign, as evident from much lower core inflation, excluding precious metals at 2.1%.

Malhotra said core inflation pressures are muted, though supply-chain issues cloud the inflation outlook



Core inflation, excluding precious metals, was at 2.1%.

measure of overall price conditions. Except for Uganda, all nations that target inflation look at headline inflation.

The debate over using core or headline inflation as the benchmark has long persisted, largely because monetary policy has limited ability to influence food prices, which are driven by supply-side factors rather than demand that interest rates can control.

Food now carries a 37% weight in the headline Consumer Price Index or CPI basket—down from 46% in the previous inflation series. In July 2024, the Economic Survey for 2023-24 suggested excluding food prices from India's inflation-targeting framework.

Malhotra said core inflation pressures are muted, though supply-chain disruptions and potential second-round effects cloud the inflation outlook. He said geopolitical uncertainties have increased significantly since the previous policy meet.

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RBI proposes steps to ease banks' capital requirements

The regulator suggests allowing quarterly profits in capital adequacy, scrapping IFR mandate

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The banking regulator on Wednesday proposed easing banks' capital requirements by allowing quarterly profits to be included in capital adequacy calculations and scrapping the mandate to maintain an investment fluctuation reserve (IFR).

Currently, banks are permitted to include their quarterly profits in the computation of their capital to risk-weighted assets ratio (CRAR). However, this is subject to incremental provisions for non-performing assets (NPAs) at the end of any of the four quarters of the previous fiscal year, provided they have not deviated by more than 25% from the average of the four quarters.

"On a review, it is proposed to dispense with this condition," RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra announced on Wednesday as part of the statement on developmental and regulatory policies released alongside the monetary policy statement. The move comes amid a benign credit cycle, with banks reporting decadal low NPAs.

The monetary policy committee kept rates unchanged at 5.25% while maintaining a 'neutral stance', citing geopolitical uncertainty and higher upside risks to inflation from the West Asia war.

The draft circular issued later in the evening said banks can include quarterly profits in the computation of their common equity tier 1 (CET1) capital, subject to a new formula which accounts for a bank's cumulative profit or loss accumulated over each quarter of a fiscal year, as well as the average dividend paid by the bank during the last three fiscal years.

At the post-policy conference, the RBI chief said banks have been



The proposed measures could free up to ₹40,000 crore for the banking system.

requesting relief, which is expected to ease access to capital amid unfavourable market conditions. "NBFCs (non-banking financial companies) already had some of the provisions. So, it was time that we aligned it," he said, adding it does not change the calculation of net

chief economic adviser Soumya Kanti Ghosh said in a note.

The central bank also proposed eliminating the requirement for banks to maintain an IFR as an additional buffer against depreciation in the value of their investments, subject to mark-

CAPITAL BUFFER RELIEF

THE move removes a condition tied to NPA provision when including quarterly profits in CRAR

BANKS can include quarterly profits in CET1 capital under a formula based on total profit or loss

RBI governor said banks sought relief for capital access amid unfavourable market conditions

RBI said IFR is no longer needed as banks maintain capital charges for most market risks

profit but changes the way capital adequacy is measured. "It is a better reflection of the capital that the banks have."

"This proposal gives considerable flexibility to banks to internal plough back," State Bank of India (SBI) group

to-market (MTM) requirements.

In his statement, the RBI governor said banks already maintain a capital charge for market risk and also follow revised norms on classification, valuation and the operation of investment

portfolios, which have warranted a review of the need for such a reserve. This will help enhance regulatory clarity and consistency, he said.

Opening up of the IFR corpus could free up around ₹35,000-40,000 crore for banks, SBI's Ghosh said, adding that this corpus can be used 'optimally and judiciously' by banks between CET-1 and P&L (profit and loss) account even when yields have moved substantially up during the last quarter.

In a later draft, RBI proposed dispensing with the IFR requirement for bank categories, maintaining a capital charge for market risk, and asked banks to instead follow the revised norms on classification, valuation, and the operation of investment portfolios. It proposed letting banks meet IFR requirements on balance-sheet dates instead of continuously, and plans to harmonize IFR instructions across bank categories to remove inconsistencies and improve clarity.

RBI has sought feedback on both the draft circulars by 29 April.

"With regard to the investment fluctuation reserve, there has been a checked history. It was there, then it was withdrawn, and then again brought in. This is something which is not there in any other jurisdiction, and there was a lack of clarity," Malhotra said in the post-policy conference.

He explained that the reserve originally allowed banks to spread investment losses, but RBI now favours mark-to-market pricing to reflect a bank's correct position. "If they price as per the market, then the very need of this fluctuation reserve goes away completely."

According to deputy governor Swaminathan J, a revamp of the capital adequacy guidelines and new norms on the valuation and disclosure of the investment book have deemed the IFR 'no longer relevant'.

RBI shifts boards' focus to strategy, risk

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Reserve Bank of India on Wednesday proposed to rationalise matters requiring bank board review, shifting the focus to strategy and risk oversight while allowing greater delegation of routine issues in a sweeping governance overhaul.

RBI, in a draft circular, suggested consolidating and simplifying board-level responsibilities, removing many existing provisions, and replacing them with a principles-based framework that clearly defines what must go to the board and what can be delegated.

RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra said the step is aimed at helping boards utilize their time effectively and to facilitate a more focused and qualitative engagement on strategy and risk governance.

"It is important to review these instructions periodically because, when they are issued, they are often not examined in a comprehensive manner. Each circular is looked at in isolation without associating



RBI has proposed consolidating and simplifying board-level responsibilities, and clarifying what can be delegated.

the overall expectations from bank boards and the pressure it places on their time," he said.

"One had been hearing from the boards that a lot of operational matters are also coming to the bank board, as a result of which they are not able to concentrate on real policy and strategic matters. So, that is why we have brought the measures."

While he didn't explicitly cite recent events, tightening of board accountability follows

The proposed framework consolidates board-level matters into structured appendices

heightened scrutiny of governance practices in private banks, especially after the sudden exit of former HDFC Bank chairman Atanu Chakraborty on 18 March.

Chakraborty resigned with immediate effect from the board, citing "certain happenings and practices within the bank" that were "not in congruence" with his personal values and ethics, prompting questions over oversight and internal controls at

India's largest private bank.

Following his resignation, in a late-night announcement, HDFC Bank said the central bank had approved the appointment of board member Keki Mistry as an interim part-time chairman for three months from 19 March.

"RBI's move to simplify regulatory guidance will enable bank boards to have a sharper focus on strategic priorities, further strengthening their risk and governance capabilities," said State Bank of India chairman C.S. Setty.

At the core of the reform is a new framework that consolidates board-level matters into structured appendices while allowing flexibility. "Board may, at its discretion, delegate certain aspects of matters to a board management committee, as indicated in appendices. Review of policies required to be placed before the board for approval may be delegated to board committees, with the board approving material amendments to such policies," the draft circular said.

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RBI shuns hawkish signal amid war shocks, keeps rates steady

FROM PAGE 1

impact growth.

For Q1, the central bank has projected growth at 6.8%, Q2 at 6.7%, Q3 at 7.0%, and Q4 at 7.2%, with risks to the baseline projections tilted to the downside. For its projections, RBI has assumed crude at an average of \$85 per barrel in FY27.

Malhotra dismissed comments on FY27 growth projections being too optimistic. "No, we don't think that it is too optimistic. However, we have mentioned that there are more risks to the downside rather than to the upside, and that will happen primarily, I would say... [if] there is a prolonged disruption in the supplies which we hope to normalize sooner than later," he said.

While the RBI reiterated the resilience of India's macroeconomic fundamentals, it acknowledged that the external shock has clouded the growth outlook. But Malhotra said that India is better placed today than in previous episodes of crises and many other economies



RBI said that headline inflation remains contained.

"Despite such a big shock, we are looking at 6.9% real GDP growth. So structurally, India in the long term, with macroeconomic fundamentals and because of various measures taken, remains quite strong," Malhotra said.

The central bank said that headline inflation remains contained and below the target. "However, upside risks to the inflation outlook driven by increased energy prices, pressures, and probable weather disturbances affecting food and

costs have increased."

For FY27, RBI has projected inflation at 4.6%, with Q1 at 4.0%, Q2 at 4.4%, Q3 at 5.2%, and Q4 at 4.7%. For the first time, RBI projected core inflation at 4.4% for FY27. It steps out the impact of the rise in food and energy prices.

"The RBI revised growth estimates lower (with downside risks) and inflation higher (with upside risks), but on balance the guidance seemed neutral to dovish, in our view, due to RBI's continuation with proactive and pre-emptive liquidity management and mention of core inflation excluding precious metals being materially lower than headline CPI estimates," Kanishk Das, chief economist at India, Malaysia, and South Asia at Deutsche Bank AG, said in a note.

Malhotra also allayed concerns on capital flows and repatriation pressures, saying that earlier outflows driven by high equity valuations are unlikely to persist.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](https://www.livemint.com).

RBI sees no systemic risk from HDFC Bank chair's exit

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MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday sought to allay governance concerns after the sudden exit of former HDFC Bank chairman Atanu Chakraborty, saying the development does not pose a systemic risk to the banking sector.

Addressing the issue at the post-policy conference, RBI deputy governor Swaminathan J said the developments are idiosyncratic and confined to the institution. "These are entity-specific developments and do not pose any systemic risk at this point in time... the banking system is old and very resilient, and we continue to focus on improving the conduct of related matters and governance related matters."

Any individual supervisory concerns, as and when they arise, are addressed on an ongoing specific basis, he said, adding that if anything warrants a regulatory tweak, then the central bank is not averse to taking such measures.

However, at this point in time, no event requires a prevention measure or a regulatory tweak, the deputy governor said, adding these are episodic events and RBI will handle it like a regular case.

Chakraborty's departure, reportedly citing "ethical and governance concerns", raised concerns across the sector, prompting questions on oversight and internal controls at one of India's largest banks. However, RBI moved swiftly to contain any spillover effects. "I would like to reiterate that no material concern is there related to governance or conduct," RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra said, answering media queries at the conference. He also said regulatory frameworks and supervisory mechanisms remain robust.

Market participants had reacted with caution, given HDFC Bank's importance and weight in benchmark indices. But, analysts said while governance lapses at large institutions can dent sentiment, the strong messaging by RBI will prevent broader contagion.

RBI also proposed a draft circular outlining how matters should be placed before bank boards, with the boards themselves deciding the periodicity, guided by the seven broad themes set by the regulator.

Governor Sanjay Malhotra's commentary offered a masterclass in calibrated central banking—demonstrating how, in periods of heightened uncertainty, words themselves can become a powerful policy instrument. The backdrop to this decision could hardly have been more fluid. Just hours before the policy announcement, a tentative ceasefire between the U.S. and Iran sent oil prices sharply lower. Yet, the durability of this truce—and critically, the

Equid calls from sections of the market to deploy unconventional tools—such as incentivizing NRI deposits—the central bank held its ground. Such measures, while effective in moments of acute external stress, carry signalling risks that can outweigh their benefits when deployed prematurely. In refraining, RBI avoided solving for a problem that has not yet fully materialized.

RBI's updated macro forecasts offer insight into this cautious pragmatism. It revised inflation forecasts upward—now estimated

This combination allows RBI to acknowledge upside risks to inflation without validating the market's aggressive rate-hike expectations. In effect, the central bank has pushed back against premature tightening—not by disputing the risks, but by contextualizing them within a still-comfortable macro starting point. This implies that support for liquidity and transmission of earlier

Sakshi Gupta is principal economist at HDFC Bank.

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LOCAL INFRASTRUCTURE, CHAIRMANSHIP OF THE BOARD OF THE TRIMBAK MUNICIPAL COUNCIL, under the Sinhashta Kumbhmelis works. The tender documents will be available on the website www.mahatenders.gov.in from 09/04/2026 to 16/04/2026 up to 05.00 PM. The last date for submission of tenders is 16/04/2026. Note: All necessary details, subsequent notices, and clarifications will be published online on the www.mahatenders.gov.in website.

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08

THURSDAY, 9 APRIL 2026
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More than 800 freighters, most of them transporting fuel and waiting to leave, remain stuck in the gulf. REUTERS

Strait stays blocked even as hundreds of ships seek transit

Bloomberg
[feedback@livemint.com](https://www.bloomberg.com/news/articles/2026-04-08/iran-threatens-to-shut-down-the-strait-of-hormuz)

The Strait of Hormuz appeared to remain largely blocked on Wednesday, as shipowners try to understand if they can safely transit the vital waterway following a ceasefire between the US and Iran that was announced overnight. A total of seven ships were seen exiting the region since Tuesday morning, while three vessels entered, tracking data compiled by Bloomberg show. Total peace time transit stood at about 135 a day last year. More than 800 freighters are stuck inside the gulf, mostly waiting to leave.

While shipowners and insurer groups lined up to welcome the cease-fire, they also warned that more details will be needed to determine if safe transit is possible. Iran has said a precondition of the ceasefire is that its armed forces should coordinate navigation through what is the world's most important oil channel. Tehran has also been charging a toll of as much as \$2 mil-

would not be advisable," said Jakob Larsen, the group's chief safety and security officer.

Those views mirrored private comments from owners with ships in the region.

Several in Asia, West Asia, and Europe said they were calling insurers and security advisers, and had put vessels on standby to transit Hormuz.

How soon flows return to normal will dictate the path ahead for global commodity prices.

The waterway, which handles a fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas, has been all but closed since US and Israeli strikes at the end of February prompted Iran to tighten its control, triggering an unprecedented oil-supply crunch.

Throughout the conflict shipowners have cited the safety of their crews as a reason not to transit. Shipowners, brokers and insurers also pointed to what they said were several apparently different versions of Iran's peace plan as one reason for a lack of clarity.

Iran says it has agreed to two weeks of safe pas-

The day Donald Trump's Iran threat gripped the world

Trump's post that a whole civilization would die if no deal was struck, sparked a frantic global guessing game

WSJ staff
feedback@livemint.com

At 8:06 a.m. Tuesday, President Trump issued the most dramatic ultimatum of his presidency: Unless Iran struck a deal in the next 12 hours, "a whole civilization will die tonight, never to be brought back again."

Even for a president who has long relied on maximalist threats, the 85-word post was startling. It ricocheted from the Oval Office to foreign embassies and corporate suites, setting off a countdown to Trump's 8 p.m. deadline and a frantic global guessing game over what the world's most powerful man was prepared to do.

Less than ninety minutes before his deadline, Trump backed down, writing in a social-media post that he had agreed to a two-week cease-fire with Iran and would suspend his threatened strikes subject to the immediate reopening of the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump had spent days warning that he would bomb Iran's bridges, power plants, and other civilian infrastructure, insisting the country's people "would be willing to suffer that in order to have freedom." As he appeared to threaten to destroy a country of 93 million people, he also seemed to leave the door open to a deal to avert the calamitous strikes. "WHO KNOWS?" he wrote on Tuesday morning. "We will find out tonight, one of the most important moments in the long and complex history of the World."

As the hours ticked by, everyone from Pope Leo to actor Ben Stiller called on Trump to back down. Administration officials fielded phone calls from executives and



Trump spent days warning that he would bomb Iran's bridges, power plants, and other civilian infrastructure. AFP

it would plunge the region into darkness if Iranian infrastructure was attacked.

Trump's post made headlines in Israel as people there were getting ready for the end of Passover. Former Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Olmert said from his shelter. "I want to believe what he meant is we will destroy the regime. I don't think we can accept any destruction, total or partial, of Iranian civilization."

At 9 a.m., Defense Secretary Pete

ing and crazy," Tim Pool, a social media personality with more than two million followers, said in an interview with *The Wall Street Journal*. If Trump fails to follow through, "we will see the emperor has no clothes... This will be his final gambit," he said in a video he filmed for his followers.

NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte was in the air en route to Washington when Trump published his social-media post. He was set to meet on Wednesday with Trump, Hegseth and Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

Some European officials huddled on a call to discuss the fallout from the president's threat. The consensus was that Trump was going to back off, two

concern about the president's threat. One White House official called Trump's post disturbing, adding that the president's focus on foreign affairs is distracting from domestic priorities that could win over the public.

Other senior administration officials and Trump allies said they viewed the Truth Social post as a negotiating tactic.

Text chains that included tech CEOs and investors lit up with concern about the potentially destabilizing effects of the president's threats after five weeks of war that have driven up oil prices and rocked the global economy, people on the threads said.

But he cautioned there was a 35% chance of further conflict, more escalation from both sides, and the Strait of Hormuz staying closed.

Bryan Lanza, a former Trump adviser who is now a corporate consultant, received a wave of inquiries from clients—including executives in the energy and finance sector—after Trump's post went up, according to a person with direct knowledge of the matter. Lanza fielded inquiries while he was on vacation in the Turks and Caicos, urging calm and arguing that Trump wouldn't follow through on his threat.

As the day wore on, Trump's threat drew reactions from all corners. "Stop the escalation. End the war now. No one wants this," actor Ben Stiller posted. Pope Leo, who has been critical of the U.S. war in Iran, called Trump's threats "truly unacceptable."

A last-ditch push for a deal
By midafternoon, with little progress, some European officials weighed in publicly. "One does not cross a civilization," French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot said in a local television interview.

Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni, one of Trump's closest European allies, also issued a rare criticism. "It is crucial to clearly distinguish between the responsibilities of a regime and the fate of millions of ordinary citizens," she said. "Iran's civilian population cannot and must not pay the price for the sins of its leaders."

This message was echoed from Capitol Hill. It would be a "huge mistake" if "Iran attacks civilian targets," Trump ally Sen. Ron Johnson (R., Wis.) said, adding that he hoped Trump was trying to "use his unpredictability" to make a deal. Dozens of Democrats called for Trump to be removed from office via the 25th

lion a transit for some carriers.

"Time will tell whether it is a pause or a peace but, in the meantime, it is highly unlikely that trade into the Gulf will simply resume," said Neil Roberts, head of marine and aviation at the Lloyd's Market Association. "The region remains at heightened risk with none of the underlying tensions resolved."

While owners publicly and privately expressed cautious optimism, they added that it still isn't clear how transits will work in practice.

A.P. Moller-Maersk A/S, the world's second-largest container line, said the pause "may create transit opportunities, but it does not yet provide full maritime certainty". Japan's NYK said it was monitoring the situation.

Bimco, a shipping trade group whose members control almost two-thirds of the world's seaborne freight capacity, also struck a cautious tone, adding that it was still awaiting the details of safe navigation plans from the US and Iran.

"Leaving the Persian Gulf without prior coordination with the US and Iran would entail heightened risk and

optimism, they added that it still isn't clear how transits will work in practice

sage in coordination with its armed forces and within 'technical limitations'.

By contrast, US President Donald Trump announced a "COMPLETE, IMMEDIATE, and SAFE OPENING" of the Strait of Hormuz. He said in a separate social-media post that the US would be "helping with the traffic build up" and "hanging around" to ensure smooth flows, options unlikely to appeal to Tehran.

"You don't switch global shipping flows back on in 24 hours," said Jennifer Parker, adjunct professor at the University of Western Australia Defence and Security Institute. "Tanker owners, insurers and crews need to believe the risk has actually reduced—not just paused."

Ships that transport energy make up a large part of the fleet that's stuck inside the gulf, data from intelligence firm Kpler show. There are currently 426 tankers hauling crude oil and clean fuels, plus 34 liquefied petroleum gas carriers and 19 liquefied natural gas vessels. The remainder are carrying dry commodities, such as agricultural or metal products, or containers.

political allies trying to decipher whether Trump's threat was a bluff or a prelude to an escalation.

European officials huddled on a call and largely convinced themselves that Trump would back off. On Wall Street, traders and executives treated the day like other Trump deadlines that have come and gone as negotiating tactic they largely expected to pass without catastrophe.

Scrambling for an off-ramp Trump's social-media post lit up group chats across the globe and set off a scramble by U.S. allies and mediators to find an off-ramp or buy more time.

As his threat made the rounds in Iran, many residents prepared for power and gas to go out and debated whether it would be safer to stay in the city or decamp for the countryside. Some dusted off old camping stoves and refilled oil canisters. "When the pain becomes deep enough, the fear fades," a 42-year-old Iranian woman said, citing five weeks of war and years of repression and economic crisis in the country.

Less than 30 minutes after Trump's post, Iranian officials told Egypt that Tehran had cut off direct communications with U.S. negotiators, according to officials from an Arab government. Officials from multiple Arab governments warned that the president's threat would likely have the opposite effect on Iran's headline Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, which had signaled that

Hegseth and Joint Chiefs Chairman Gen. Dan Caine logged on to their daily secure videoconference with Adm. Brad Cooper, the commander of U.S. Central Command. Cooper and military planners at the Pentagon had been preparing for potential strikes on Iran's energy infrastructure, according to two U.S. officials. Military planners pulled out existing target lists that had already been reviewed and vetted by military lawyers.

Officials said the list of targets was far fewer than Trump's threat that "every power plant in Iran will be out of business, burning, exploding." Each target was legally viable, officials said, because it had a clear connection to Iran's military and security forces and wouldn't harm the civilian population excessively. Overnight, the U.S. military pounded more than 50 targets on Kharg Island, but didn't strike oil infrastructure, according to U.S. officials.

"The entire Department serves at the direction of the President and will execute his military objectives without fail," Pentagon spokesman Sean Parnell said.

"We will see the emperor has no clothes" Trump's threat set off similar discussions among Trump allies and influencers, who engaged in furious speculation on live streams and podcasts. "He's trying to sound threaten-

of the officials on the call said.

In Budapest, Vice President JD Vance took the stage with Hungarian President Viktor Orbán. "I hope they're smart," Vance said about the Iranians. "The president has set a deadline for about 12 hours from now in the United States. We're going to find out but there's going to be a lot of negotiation between now and then."

At 10:30 a.m., Fox News host Bret Baier appeared on air with a message from the president. He said Trump had told him that "8 p.m. is happening," adding, "If we get to that point, there is going to be an attack like they have not seen."

With the clock ticking on his self-imposed deadline, Trump seemed to vacillate between last-minute diplomacy to head off a major escalation and more mundane activities. In the morning, he phoned into a rally at a sports arena in Budapest headlined by Vance, who displayed his cellphone on stage before thousands of Orbán supporters.

He held meetings with tech investor David Sacks and Justice Department officials at the White House, according to a person familiar with the matter. He fired off more than two dozen Truth Social posts endorsing candidates for Indiana state legislative races.

Inside the Trump administration, some officials privately expressed

Sovereign-wealth funds located in Gulf countries—several of which have been bombed by Iran in recent weeks—have been major investors in the AI revolution that has been powering both the tech sector and U.S. economic growth during Trump's second term.

If they had to invest more in defense, they would not be able to invest as much in America's AI boom, people who have talked to the funds' leaders said.

On Wall Street, traders were hesitant to be out on a limb when Trump had so often changed direction and while many expected Trump to launch an attack, few were betting the most realistic scenario was widespread destruction.

Citigroup amended protocols much like it does around a presidential election, such as pausing any minor coding updates to its trading tools or anything else that could slow operations, people familiar with the matter said.

"It's been dizzying," said Peter Boockvar, chief investment officer at OnePoint BFG Wealth Partners. "There is one eye on the market screens and one on Trump's Truth Social page."

Carlyle Vice Chairman James Stavridis, a retired U.S. Navy admiral, gave an internal briefing to executives saying he believed that the chances of a ceasefire in the next few weeks were about 65% because both sides are incentivized to negotiate.

Amendment or other means.

Soon after, there were the first signals that Trump's deadline could slip as U.S. allies pushed for more time for diplomacy. Shortly after 3 p.m., Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif publicly called on Trump to extend his ultimatum by two weeks and back a U.S.-Iran ceasefire, urging Tehran in turn to reopen the Strait of Hormuz for the same period as a goodwill gesture.

"The President has been made aware of the proposal, and a response will come," White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said in response to Pakistan's appeal. Trump later told Fox News the U.S. was in "heated negotiations" to reach a deal with Iran.

The president spent most of the afternoon huddled up with key aides in the Oval Office, talking calls and listening to pros and cons of the proposal.

At 6:32 p.m., Trump announced on Truth Social that he would hold off on his planned strikes. "[Subject to the Islamic Republic of Iran agreeing to the COMPLETE, IMMEDIATE, and SAFE OPENING of the Strait of Hormuz, I agree to suspend the bombing and attack of Iran for a period of two weeks]," he wrote.

Some U.S. officials said they were worried Iran wouldn't fully meet Trump's demands, potentially bringing both Washington and Tehran back to the brink in two weeks.

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Pakistan to host US-Iran peace talks tomorrow

AFP
feedback@livemint.com
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan's prime minister Shehbaz Sharif said on Wednesday that Islamabad would host delegations from the US and Iran later this week following their ceasefire announcement.

"I... extend deepest gratitude to the leadership of both the countries and invite their delegations to Islamabad on Friday, 10th April 2026, to further negotiate for a conclusive agreement to settle all disputes," he said in a post on X.

Pakistan, which has forged a close relationship with US president Donald Trump and is sensitive to developments in neighbouring Iran, has emerged as a channel for messaging between Tehran and



Pakistan prime minister Shehbaz Sharif. REUTERS

Washington in recent weeks.

"We earnestly hope, that the Islamabad Talks' succeed in achieving sustainable peace and wish to share more good news in coming days," Sharif said.

Both Tehran and Washing-

ton said they had agreed to a two-week ceasefire barely an hour before Trump's deadline to obliterate Iran was set to expire.

The war began when Israel and the US launched strikes on Iran that killed its supreme

leader on 28 February, sparking retaliatory attacks from Tehran on Gulf nations and Israel.

Lebanon has also been drawn into the conflict after Iran-backed group Hezbollah launched attacks on Israel, which has since carried out strikes, including on the capital, and launched a ground operation in the south of the country.

Sharif said the ceasefire applied "everywhere" including Lebanon, though Israel later said it would not stop its aerial and ground operations there against Hezbollah militants.

The temporary ceasefire came after a down-to-the-wire bid by Pakistan and other mediators to avert Trump's threat to destroy all power plants and bridges across Iran.

a move that legal experts said could constitute a war crime.

Turkey and Egypt had also been helping mediate in recent days. China helped get Iran to the negotiating table, Trump told AFP on Wednesday.

Sharif, in a separate X post, said China, Saudi Arabia, Turkey, Egypt and Qatar had all provided "support towards reaching the ceasefire and giving peaceful diplomatic efforts a chance".

The Pakistani leader also thanked Arab Gulf nations for their "commitment to peace and stability in the region".

Despite trading missile fire with Iran two years ago and holding an at-times rocky relationship with the United States, Pakistan currently shares war ties with both countries.

Trump may meet Nato's Rutte as he mulls exit from alliance

AP
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WASHINGTON

North Atlantic Treaty Organization (Nato) secretary-general Mark Rutte is expected to meet with US president Donald Trump on Wednesday to try to smooth over the president's anger with the military alliance over the Iran war.

Trump had suggested the US may consider leaving the trans-Atlantic alliance after Nato member countries ignored his call to help reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a vital shipping waterway, as Iran effectively shut it and sent gas prices soaring.

The Republican president's

meeting with Rutte, with whom he had a warm relationship, comes as the US and Iran late Tuesday agreed to a two-week ceasefire that includes the reopening of the strait.

The nascent ceasefire was struck after Trump said he would strike Iran's power plants and bridges, threatening that "a whole civilisation will die tonight". The plan to reopen the strait is still cloudy and is expected to be a central focus of the Wednesday afternoon meeting with Rutte. The White House said the meeting was expected to be behind closed doors. In the Trump administration, though, that can change at the last minute, and meetings can be opened to the press.

Congress in 2023 passed a law that prevents any US president from pulling out of Nato without its approval. Trump has been a longtime critic of Nato and in his first term had suggested he had the authority on his own to leave the alliance, which was founded in 1949 to counter the Cold War threat posed to European security by the Soviet Union.

The crux of the commitment its 32 member countries make is a mutual defence agreement in which an attack on one is considered an attack on them all. The only time it has been activated was in 2001, to support the US in the wake of the 11 September attacks on New York and Washington.

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NEWS WRAP

THURSDAY, 9 APRIL 2026
CHENNAI

09



\$6 bn

THE VALUE of dollar-denominated bonds sold by Poland, its first international sale since the Iran war began, including 5-, 10-, and 30-year tranches

170

NET NEW stores added by Titan Company in Q4 FY26, including 42 in India, taking its total store count across consumer businesses to 3,603 globally

\$2 mn

THE PER-SHIP fee Iran proposes to levy for transit through the Strait of Hormuz as part of US-Iran ceasefire framework, to be used mainly for post-war reconstruction

₹1 tn

THE COMBINED residential sales Godrej Properties, Lodha, DLF, and Prestige Estates, aim to cross in FY26, according to their sales guidance

6.9%

INDIA'S GDP growth forecast for FY27—lower than the 7.6% growth in FY26—by the Reserve Bank of India at its April monetary policy committee meeting

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Re surges 52p to close at 92.54 to a dollar



Rupee rose after the US, Iran reached a ceasefire and the RBI kept the repo rate unchanged. REUTERS

The rupee appreciated 52 paise to close at 92.54 against the US dollar on Wednesday after US president Donald Trump announced the suspension of military strikes against Iran for two weeks, and the Reserve Bank

of India kept the key benchmark rate unchanged with a neutral stance.

Forex traders said investor sentiment got a boost after governor Sanjay Malhotra assured that the steps taken on forex do not constitute a structural change. Moreover, confidence was exuded in the health of the banking system, notwithstanding recent developments in some private banks. Malhotra said the banking sector regulator did not come across any governance or conduct-related issues during the supervisory inspection of HDFC Bank.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 92.92 against the US dollar, then gained ground to touch 92.45 against the US dollar during the session and finally ended the day at 92.54 against the greenback, registering an increase of 52 paise over its previous close.

On Tuesday, the rupee had settled 16 paise down at 93.06 against the US dollar. PTI



Higher deficits a risk amid defence spending surge

PPFAS to manage funds under NPS



Vingroup to invest \$8.5 bn in M'rasht

Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnis on Wednesday said Vietnam-based Vingroup has committed to invest \$8.5 billion in Maharashtra over the next two years in various sectors, including electric mobility solutions, renewable energy, tourism and entertainment.

An official release earlier mentioned the investment figure as \$8.5 billion.

A memorandum of understanding (MoU) was signed between Vingroup, the state industries department and the Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority (MMRDA) in the presence of CM Fadnis at his official residence 'Varsha', the statement said. Fadnis said at the event that the investment by the Vietnamese conglomerate would accelerate sustainable development, green energy adoption, modern infrastructure and dynamic mobility systems in the state. PTI



PPFAS Asset Management on Wednesday said it has received approval from the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRA) to become a sponsor for a pension fund under the National Pension System (NPS).

In a statement, the company said it will soon start managing the retirement savings of people who invest through NPS. It will set up a separate pension fund company that will run the schemes and grow these savings over time.

"Managing retirement savings is a significant responsibility, and we are committed to handling it with care, discipline, and a long-term approach," said Neil Parag Parikh, chairman and CEO of PPFAS Asset Management.

Morgan Stanley debuts bitcoin ETF

Morgan Stanley is set to become the first Wall Street bank to launch its own bitcoin-tracking exchange-traded fund, a milestone for the digital-asset ecosystem that underscores how deeply the original cryptocurrency has embedded itself in the financial mainstream—even as the market around it has cooled. The firm was to debut the Morgan Stanley Bitcoin Trust on NYSE Arca under the ticker MSBT Wednesday. It joins more than 10 spot-Bitcoin ETFs that launched over the past two years and collectively command over \$85 billion in assets. Despite being a late entrant to a crowded field, it's leaning on a classic Wall Street playbook: competing on fees and scale.



Silver rose nearly 5% to ₹2,51,000 per kg from Tuesday's closing level of ₹2,40,000 per kg.

Silver, gold script sharp comeback

Silver prices surged ₹11,000 to ₹2.51 lakh per kilogram in New Delhi on Wednesday, while gold advanced to ₹1,56,400 per 10 grams amid strong global cues after the US and Iran agreed to a two-week ceasefire.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, the white metal zoomed by ₹11,000, or nearly 5%, to ₹2,51,000 per kg (inclusive of all taxes) from Tuesday's closing level of ₹2,40,000 per kg.

Gold of 99.9% purity also appreciated by ₹3,200, or 2.09%, to ₹1,56,400 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes). It settled at ₹1,53,200 per 10 grams in the previous market session.

Analysts said bullion prices strengthened as geopolitical tensions in West Asia eased, triggering a broader relief rally across global financial markets. Gold maintained strong gains and approached a three-week high on Wednesday as improved global risk sentiment, along with a pullback in US dollar and crude oil prices, boosted demand for precious metals. Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst of Commodities at HDFC Securities, said, "The positive momentum came on the back of US-Iran ceasefire and, conditional reopening of the Strait of Hormuz."

Spending, says IMF

'Defence build-ups boost economic activity in short term but add to public debt over time'

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Booms in defence spending pose a risk to economies in the medium term, as these expenditures are mainly financed through higher deficits, according to a report from the International Monetary Fund (IMF).

Defence build-ups typically boost economic activity in the short term by lifting consumption and investment, but over time they add to public debt, the IMF said in a report.

"More frequent conflicts and rising geopolitical tensions have prompted many countries to reassess their security priorities and increase defence spending," IMF researchers Hippolyte Ballina, Andresa Lagerberg and Evgenia Weaver said in a blogpost. "Others plan to do so. This situation presents policymakers with a crucial question about trade-offs involved."

Countries from Germany to France have lifted military expenditures in recent years, confronted with the war in Ukraine and US President Donald Trump's pressure to make Europe take greater responsibility for its own defence.

In the US, the Trump administration in its latest budget asked Congress for a significant boost in defence spending, after launching a military strike in Venezuela to capture then President Nicolas Maduro and starting a war against Iran.

Drawing on data from more than 160 countries since 1946, the IMF identified 215 cycles of increased spending in defence, saying many were concentrated in the 1970s and 1980s but that large booms have become more frequent.

The economists found that in a typical defence boom, which lasts more than two and a half years, about two-thirds of expenditures are financed through borrowing. But the cost is higher during wartime, they said. "Wartime booms are especially costly, with public debt jumping by about 14 percentage points of GDP and social spending falling in real terms," the IMF said in the report, which is part of the World Economic Outlook to be published next week. "Defence spending booms are front-loaded and financed primarily through higher deficits."

The IMF defines a defence spending boom as a period when the two-year moving average of a country's military outlays increase by at least 1% of GDP.



Hardeep Singh Brar, president and CEO, BMW Group India.

'Fuel price worries lift EV demand'

The war in West Asia is aiding demand for luxury electric vehicles driven by concerns over fuel prices among customers, BMW Group India president and CEO Hardeep Singh Brar said on Wednesday.

The German luxury carmaker has increased its EV sales in India to 26% of its overall sales in the first quarter of 2026 as compared to 21% in the year-ago period, Brar told PTI.

BMW Group India posted its highest-ever Q1 car sales, with 4,567 units in the first quarter of 2026, at a growth of 17% year-on-year.

Explaining the growth drivers, he said apart from new product launches, "because of the ongoing geopolitics and geo-economic issues which are going on globally, there was a lot of discussion on crude oil prices going up as a result of this, lot of sentiments in terms of fuel prices going up in India... So that brought in a lot of focus on electric vehicles".

FCL defaults on ₹615.67 cr payment

Future Consumer Ltd (FCL) has defaulted on the payment of ₹615.67 crore in interest and principal repayments on loans from banks, financial institutions, and unlisted debt securities, as of March-end 2026.

FCL, the FMCG arm of the debt-ridden Future Group, had defaulted on the payment of ₹325.26 crore loans and revolving facilities, like cash credit from banks and financial institutions, as of 31 March 2026. This includes both bank repayment and interest default, according to a regulatory filing by the company. The firm has an outstanding total default of ₹290.41 crore, over loans from unlisted debt securities—NCDS and NCRPs, for the same period. This includes a principal outstanding of ₹158.82 crore and accrued interest of ₹131.59 crore. FCL said the "company is planning/working for asset monetization and debt reduction over the period in this year."

India adds 55.29GW non-fossil capacity

India added record non-fossil power generation capacity of 55.29GW in 2025-26, taking the total to 283.46GW, new and renewable energy minister Pralhad Joshi said on Wednesday. Joshi also said India ranks third globally in renewable energy installed capacity, according to the Renewable Energy Statistics 2026.

India has surpassed Brazil to secure third position in Global Renewable Energy Rankings, he said while addressing a press conference in New Delhi. Joshi highlighted that in July 2025, India reached its highest-ever renewable energy share, meeting 31.5% of the country's total electricity demand of 203GW. He said that a total of 283.46 GW of capacity from non-fossil fuel sources has been installed in the country as on 31 March 2026. India's total power generation during 2025-26 (up to March 2026) reached 1,845,921 BU. The share of non-fossil fuels in total generation reached 29.2% in 2025-26 (338,97 BU).

DGCA orders upgrades by 2027 to make planes 5G safe

FROM PAGE 1

and from using enhanced flight vision systems for touchdown in aircraft with radio altimeters that are not tolerant of 5G airwaves.

"There are airplanes with an old generation of altimeters, which can cause interference with 5G currently and 6G in the upper C-band in future such as 4.4-4.8GHz," said Bharat Bhatia, president of ITU-APT Foundation of India, which works with industry and government on telecom policy. "The altimeter replacement is the only solution, which could take time owing to a similar demand from other developing countries."

According to Bhatia, current rules restrict 5G operations within 2.1 km of the runway ends and within 90 metres of the runway centreline—zones that cover terminal areas at most Indian airports. It effectively limits 5G deployment within airport premises, he said.

The extended band, such as 3.7-4.2GHz, allowed to support 5G services in other countries, is restricted in India, he said.

In response to Mint's emailed queries, Boeing said, "We'll defer to the airline operators for any comments." Honeywell Aerospace, a key manufacturer of radio altimeters used in



The retrofitting must be done by 31 December 2027.

planes, said, "We are currently in direct engagement with the concerned authorities, including civil aviation ministry and DGCA and are responding to the query."

Queries emailed to the department of telecommunications (DoT), the civil aviation ministry, IndiGo, Akasa, SpiceJet, the Cellular Operators Association of India (Coai) on the matter did not elicit any response until press time.

"Regarding the 5G rollout, as part of a wider industry coalition, we continue to work with the FAA and other involved agencies to study the issue further and work toward solutions," Airbus said in a statement. An Air India official said that

work on retrofit or upgrade of altimeters started "long time back". The airline will be fully compliant before the said deadline," the official said. "Some of the narrow-body Airbus aircraft we have are already updated and work is ongoing in some," the official said, without giving a breakup.

To be sure, telecom operators are also relying on in-building solutions inside airports and 4G spectrum bands such as 2,100MHz and 2,300MHz for mobile services. There are concerns regarding 5G/6G services, but 6G is expected only by 2030, said a government official, speaking on condition of anonymity. "The expectation is that the altimeters can be modified before that."

There is a global demand for replacing such altimeters, which is delaying the replacement process in India, said an executive with an aircraft maker. Airline operators have been working with aircraft and equipment manufacturers to fix altimeters for the past couple of years, the executive said.

According to FlightGlobal, a London-based aerospace publisher, airlines in the US say they can speed up altimeter upgrades for 5G but want compensation for the costs involved.

Air India official said that

FROM PAGE 1

tive all-clear. Sudeep Shah of SBI Securities had a different take. "The recent upmove in Nifty appears to be more than just a relief rally, supported by strong price action, improving breadth, and positive momentum indicators," said Shah, who heads technical and derivatives research at the broking firm. The breakout above the 20-day exponential moving average and easing volatility suggest a shift toward a short-term bullish trend rather than a mere bounce, Shah added.

The BSE's market capitalization increased by ₹16 trillion on Wednesday. The rally was broad-based, with the Nifty Smallcap and Midcap indices gaining 3.9% and 4.03% higher. All of Nifty's sectoral indices closed in green. Adding to the positive tone was the central bank's decision to keep the repo rate unchanged at 5.25%.

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) net sold shares worth ₹2,811 crore in secondary markets on Wednesday, provisional data from BSE showed. DIIs net bought shares worth ₹4,168 crore.

Global markets rejoiced as well, with South Korea's KOSPI rising 6.8%, Japan's Nikkei 5.4%, China's CSI 300 3.5%, and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index 3.1%. Oil plunged over 7% to \$80 a barrel 12% following the ceasefire, while the rupee gained 50 paise during the day.

However, oil remains below the



The BSE's market capitalization increased by ₹16 trillion on Wednesday. The rally was broad-based.

pre-war level of ₹73.91, indicating that even with the ceasefire announcement, the risk premium still exists.

Dover of Franklin Templeton said the damage is done as energy infrastructure across the Gulf has been hit, and restoring full production capacity will take time. "Supply normalization won't be immediate, which means that oil, natural gas and fertilizer prices probably won't fall quickly back to pre-war levels," he added.

This comes on the back of already slowing earnings growth. Net sales growth of 7.26% y-o-y in the third quarter of fiscal year 2026 (Q3FY26) and net profit growth of 2.37% y-o-y in Q3FY26.

Earnings growth expectations for the Nifty for FY27 have moderated from 16% earlier to around

12%, and valuations have corrected sharply, said Devarsh Vakil, head of prime research at HDFC Securities. "The combination of steady earnings growth and scope for valuation re-rating makes current levels attractive for long-term investors," he added.

With this, the Nifty's trailing price-to-earnings is at 22.2x, closer to its 10-year average PE of 23.2x. Since the war began, FPIs have net sold shares worth ₹1.72 trillion in primary and secondary markets. DIIs have provided strong support during the time, with \$15 billion in inflows in March largely from SIPs, pensions, and insurance, said Jaising of ASK Private Wealth. However, at the current pace, DII support may sustain markets for only another month if FII outflows persist, Jaising added.

KERALA'S FISCAL MESS LOOMS OVER THE BALLOT BOX

The state's ability to raise taxes has declined. And consumption could be hit because of the West Asia crisis

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM/KOCHI

nas K. Hamza, from Palakkad in Kerala, rarely gets to vote



An Indian elections despite his strong political views. A mechanical supervisor at an oil rig in Abu Dhabi, he has spent the last 18 years in West Asia and Africa. But he will vote in the Kerala state assembly elections on 9 April—the war in West Asia has delayed his return to Abu Dhabi.

"I want change," he said. Not that he is unhappy with the current Left Democratic Front (LDF) government led by octogenarian Communist Party of India (Marxist) leader Pinarayi Vijayan. "This government has done a decent job but 10 years is a long time for any party to be in power," he added.

Syam Sankar from Mallapuram and an Uber driver in Thiruvananthapuram echoed Hamza's views. "A new government will do better and we need to give younger people a chance," he said.

This need for change, the anti-incumbency—not necessarily due to poor governance—is proving to be the biggest challenge for LDF as it seeks to deliver a hat-trick, something no party has managed ever in the state's history.

Between the late 1980s and now, political power in Kerala alternated between LDF and the United Democratic Front (UDF), headed by the Congress Party. In 2021, LDF broke that trend and improved on its 2016 performance to retain power in the 140-member Kerala Assembly.

There is some discontent as well. "Only people outside Kerala think we have a communist party running the government. In reality, CPM is like any other party," said Muralidharan M., a teacher in Kottayam. "Chief minister Vijayan has been behaving like a king."

Lack of jobs, especially for educated youth, is hurting LDF. Opinion polls give UDF an edge.

A third player in the polls is the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—it is promising a change from both LDF and UDF. The party is on a high after winning the recent local body elections in Thiruvananthapuram. It is expected to improve its vote share in the coming elections. However, in the previous state polls, BJP drew a blank. In fact, the only time it has ever won an assembly seat was back in 2016—the Nemon constituency in Thiruvananthapuram.

As the LDF and the UDF battle each other, what is certain is that the next government will have to deal with a serious financial crisis. The state's finances are already precarious. It struggles to pay salaries and pending payments run into hundreds of crores. With the state pay commission set to announce a hike in salaries, the wage bill is all set to rise. Also, consumption is likely to take a beating as the West Asia crisis upsets the flow of remittances which account for 18% of Kerala's economy.

"The next government will have the unenviable task of managing this mess," said K.P. Kannan, a development economist and former director at the Centre for Development Studies, Thiruvananthapuram.

SEEKING CONTINUITY

Asome drives across Kerala, huge banners stating 'Mattarundu LDF alatha' (who else other than LDF) dot the main thoroughfares of Thiruvananthapuram, Kocchi, Kottayam, Adoor and other large towns of the state. LDF has been spending to highlight its performance on eradicating poverty, building infrastructure, providing old-age pension and allotting houses for all.

"In the last 10 years, the government has done well when it comes to education, healthcare, social security, building roads and bridges. There have been no communal clashes or cases of corruption and hence there is no anti-incumbency," said V. Sivankutty, minister for general education and labour in the LDF government. "People are happy and the LDF will come back to power," he added during his campaign trail in Thiruvananthapuram. He is contesting from Nemon constituency.

To counter the narrative of needing change, LDF has been highlighting the need for continuity. "It took more than five years to eliminate extreme poverty in the state. That was possible because of continuity," pointed out P. Rajeev, minister for law, industries and coir. The state, he added, is now primed for investment. It tops the ease of doing business ranking and investments have started to flow. "We

Kerala's precarious finances notwithstanding, UDF has announced five guarantees, including a welfare pension increase and healthcare cover of up to ₹25 lakh per family.

in the local body polls last year, UDF bagged the maximum seats across the state. "We hope to get more than 100 seats and win comfortably," he told *Mint* while reviewing a few promotional videos from his campaign team. "I have travelled across the state twice and I can tell you there is huge anti-incumbency."

The government employees have not been paid their dues and arrears alone exceed ₹1 trillion, he claimed. Various services including healthcare, have declined for lack of funding. Farmers have not been paid the minimum statutory price and there has been no procurement of rice, rubber or coconut. "People are suffering and they have no intention of voting LDF back to power," Satheesan added.

Kerala's precarious finances notwithstanding, UDF has announced five

have attracted investments worth ₹3.3 trillion and more will come if LDF returns to power," he said. As many as 15 lakh jobs have been created so far and more will be created if the policies continue, he added. Apart from need for change, LDF is also battling perception issues. UDF has been accusing LDF of having a tacit understanding with the BJP. If this accusation sticks, LDF could lose minority votes that enabled it to retain power comfortably in 2021.

"LDF has done a lot to protect the interest of minorities, we are confident that we will get their support," said Rajeev.

Across most constituencies in south Kerala, LDF has activated its disciplined cadre to reach out to the people and ensure a historic third term.

ANOTHER OPPORTUNITY

In contrast, an air of confidence pervades V.D. Satheesan's office in Paravur, a 30-minute drive from Kocchi. The

guarantees. This includes free bus travel for women, an increase in welfare pension, healthcare cover of up to ₹25 lakh per family and cash support for college-going girls.

"These guarantees won't worsen the financial position of the state," he responded when asked about the financial implication of the sops. He is also confident that the consolidation of minority votes, especially in north Kerala, will work in UDF's favour.

But what can derail its chances is infighting among the leaders. He denies there is one. "There is no infighting. The seats were allotted among partners and within the Congress Party in 48 hours and without any dissent," Satheesan said.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, during his recent campaign, emphasised the need for UDF partners and Congressmen to work together to ensure the front's victory.

VIKASHITA KERALAM

In 12 noon and Thiruvananthapuram is unusually hot. Kerala BJP leader Rajiv Chandrasekhar visits houses as part of his campaign at Karanam which falls under the Nemon assembly constituency. Sipping filter coffee in this predominantly Brahmin neighbourhood, he listens to the woes narrated by people. Complaints range from the lack of drinking water to the need for cleaning the Karanam river on the lines of Namami Ganga.

Speaking to *Mint* between his campaign stops, Chandrasekhar said that for the first time in the history of Kerala, people seek an alternative in BJP.

"Till now, it was a Hobson's choice between LDF and UDF," he said. "Now BJP is offering an alternate model of governance based on an alternate mode of government. Narendra Modi has delivered in the last 12 years. People are listening."

Post-elections, he expects a major change in political landscape of Kerala, he said. BJP would become a force to reckon with.

His confidence stems from the rising vote share of the saffron party in the state. In the 2021 state assembly election, the party garnered 11.3% of the votes polled. It shot up to 19.2% during the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. In last



BJP and LDF supporters gather on the final day of campaigning at Perorkada, Thiruvananthapuram, on 7 April 2026.

MINT KEY NUMBERS

18%

The portion of Kerala's economy accounted for by remittances from West Asia, a figure now at risk due to regional instability

34.2%

Kerala's outstanding debt as a percentage of its GDP, a ratio that experts warn indicates a long-term debt trap.

71%

Percentage of the state's revenue receipts immediately consumed by committed expenses like salaries, pensions, and interest.

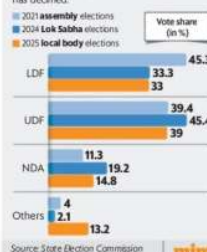
THE TALLY

In 2021, LDF enjoyed a comfortable majority in the 140-member Kerala assembly.



The swing

In recent elections, LDF's vote share has declined.



committed expenses such as salaries, pension and interest payments. Not surprising that its capital expenditure, at 1.4% of GDP, is among the lowest in the country. "Kerala has been in a debt trap for the last 10 years," Kannan said. With the wage and pension bill set to rise sharply due to the pay commission recommendation, the financial crisis is only set to worsen.

Both BJP and UDF have come up with a plan to shore up the state's finances. BJP's manifesto calls for an economic rebuilding. It has promised an investment and job revolution. Kerala's highly educated youth typically goes elsewhere, within India or outside, for jobs. "We want to end this practice by accelerating economic growth and creating jobs," Chandrasekhar said. Infrastructure is another area of focus. BJP has promised a high-speed rail network connecting Thiruvananthapuram in the south and Kannur in north Kerala. Unlike all other states, Kerala's highways are still two-lane roads. It took this writer over seven hours to travel between Thiruvananthapuram and Kocchi through Kottayam—a distance of mere 210 kilometres. Delhi to Agra, similar in distance by road, doesn't take more than three hours.

Congress leader Satheesan says the state's financial management needs to be improved and for that he wants the tax administration to be revamped. Kerala, he said, was a consumption economy and with the introduction of GST, a consumption-based tax, its revenue should have risen sharply. "That has not happened because unlike other states Kerala has not re-structured its tax administration after GST was introduced," he explained.

He also blames large-scale leakages for poor revenue mobilisation. "Kerala's tax collection from gold has remained flat despite gold prices rising sharply. This shows something is fundamentally wrong and needs to be fixed," he added.

These steps may not be enough. The next government will have to find ways to increase taxes, cut subsidies and charge for some public services. These measures won't be popular—except the new government's honeymoon period with the voters to be a short one.



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hidden traps to watch out

Design-led nudges such as false urgency, default add-ons, and drip pricing are now common

Amritha
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MUMBAI

Buying an insurance plan remains one of the toughest financial chores. From calculating how much cover you need to decoding policy features, the homework is already heavy. Now imagine a portal flashing three extra add-ons with a "skip and you miss one-in-a-lifetime opportunity" pitch. Fatigue meets FOMO—and you click "add".

This is a classic dark pattern: a design-led nudge pushing you to buy more than intended. The insurance regulator has now sounded a warning. Dark patterns are subtle digital "nudges" designed to manipulate consumer choices and inflate premiums. While common in e-commerce, they are increasingly embedded in insurance journeys. Recognizing the growing threat to consumer trust, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) issued guidelines 2 April.

Insurers and regulated e-platforms were directed to comply with the Central Consumer Protection Authority's 2023 guidelines on dark patterns. Entities have 15 days to self-assess and a month for a "clean-up" action plan.

Choice by design
The rise of dark patterns is closely tied to insurance going digital. Aayush Dubey, research head and co-founder of Beshak.org Insurance, says online shift has altered how policies are sold. "Most buying and renewal decisions happen online, where the way options are shown, selected, or explained, can influence customer choices," Dubey said. "Even small design elements, like what is pre-selected or what is made more visible, can influence decisions at that moment."

Manoj K. Pandey, associate professor at BIMTECH, said these are deliberate systems, not glitches. "Dark patterns are inbuilt algorithms influencing cognitive-behavioural response of online shoppers. The most common tools are generating a sense of urgency, easy entry but difficult exits, and adding additional items without consent."

The 13 traps
The CCPA has identified 13 dark patterns on digital platforms that can lock insurance buyers into long-term commitments without full awareness.

False urgency: Notes like "3 people are viewing this policy right now".

Basket sneaking: Add-ons or riders added without explicit consent.

Confirm shaming: Language that is designed to induce guilt, such as "No, I don't want to protect my family".

Auto-renew traps: Policy renewed without clear, explicit consent.

Drip pricing: Final premium (plus GST and fees) revealed at checkout.

Nagging: Repeated pop-ups pushing users to "opt-in" or "renew".

Local circles: Survey found six in 10 online insurance consumers faced such traps, especially in non-life segments where renewals and variable pricing enable manipulation.

Shilpa Arora, co-founder and COO of Insurance Samadhan, describes the underlying theme as "consumer nudging without full awareness".

Non-life insurance
Non-life insurance, like health and motor cover, is more prone to these

Dark patterns: beware the digital nudge

As insurance sales move online, design tricks such as pre-ticked riders, confusing pricing and renewal traps are pushing consumers into choices they may not fully understand.

Dark patterns when you are buying insurance

Platforms may add riders to your cart without you clicking it.

Confirm shaming with a button that says, "No, I don't want to protect my family" instead of "No".

Drip pricing is about showing the base price initially then loading it up with GST and add-on costs at checkout.

Policies can be bought in one click but canceling may need multiple phone calls.

Constant pop-ups to "upgrade" while one is trying to understand the features of a policy.



Steer clear of dark patterns

Here are some things to check

Before paying, check if any "Add-ons" or "Riders" were added to the total.

If a premium looks significantly lower than competitors, go through the features to understand the trade-offs.

If the user interface makes purchases easy but opt-out options are difficult, proceed with caution.

AAYUSH DUBEY
Co-founder, Beshak.org



"Most buying and renewals happen online, where the way options are shown, selected, or small design elements can influence customer choices."

MANOJ K. PANDEY
Associate professor, BIMTECH



"The most common dark pattern tools are generating a sense of urgency, easy entry but difficult exit, and adding additional items without consent."

SHILPA ARORA
Co-founder and COO, Insurance Samadhan



"Platforms will need to enable genuine comparison based on coverage and suitability, not just price. From 'easy to buy' to 'easy to understand'."

tactics as transactions are frequent and ticket sizes smaller. "In health insurance, these patterns are more visible during renewal," Dubey said. "A higher sum insured may be selected when you open the renewal page or certain add-ons may be included by default."

In motor insurance, price distortion is common. Public databases such as VAHAN enable mass outreach by multiple sellers, creating confusion via price undercutting, noted Arora. Add-ons like "zero depreciation" may be pre-selected—or omitted—to make quotes appear cheaper, resulting in significant coverage gaps at claim time.

Travel insurance
Travel insurance was among the earliest examples of dark patterns. Pandey recalls when airline portals made insurance a compulsory, "pre-ticked" item. "People were getting insured without knowing they had bought a policy because the cost seemed lower compared to the original purchase," he said. Irdai intervened, making "opt-in" mandatory. "After that, sales fell drastically, not even reaching 20% of what they were earlier."

Claim shock
The damage surfaces not at purchase but at renewal or claim stage. "Renewal is designed to make switch-

ing or comparing alternatives difficult," said Arora. "Coverage tweaks or sub-limits may change at renewal, but are buried in the fine print."

This leads to "claim shock"—when consumers realize the renewed policy no longer matches what they originally bought. Pandey said intrusion extends beyond digital interfaces. "The intrusion is not limited to the digital route; unsolicited calls from unrelated parties are very common and irritating."

Poor data privacy also fuels this ecosystem, where policy expiry data is sold to competing insurers who aggressively "nag" consumers to switch.

Penetration gap
Despite rising manipulation, online insurance penetration remains low. Pandey cited Irdai data showing online channels contributed only 0.8% of life business and 1.68% of health business in 2024-25.

However, with the push towards "insurance for All by 2047", digital is set to increase. "The business officials, particularly the digital innovators, are very smart. I personally do not see this intervention from the regulatory authority as a full stop. It has to be a regular practice," he added.

Consumer awareness
Pro-active regulation beyond paperwork compliance and stricter penalties

that make misuse costlier than profit may make way for reforms, he said.

Mindful click
"Platforms will need to enable genuine comparison based on coverage and suitability, not just price," Arora said. "The biggest shift will be from 'easy to buy' to 'easy to understand'."

Dubey cautioned that while regulators can clean up interfaces, the final click still rests with the consumer.

Vinit Iyer, co-founder of Prudeno Wealth, warns that online convenience often masks coverage gaps. "Online platforms may select features reducing the premium, which the client thinks is a discount, but it may come back to bite at the time of claim," Iyer cited "Smart Select" feature as an example, where a 15-20% premium reduction may come with heavy co-payment requirements at non-work hospitals.

Iyer adds that automated platforms often fail to explain high-impact features while promoting superficial ones like basic annual checkups simply to close sales. He advocates intermediaries for complex decisions.



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should you diversify into realty?

Rakshit H.D.

At 40, I got a ₹75 lakh windfall. I already have a portfolio with 60% towards equity mutual funds. Does adding real estate make sense for long-term diversification and retirement planning?

How should one balance risk and returns for goals like retirement and children's education over the next 6-8 years, and what kind of tax-efficient allocation and rebalancing strategy would you suggest?

—Name withheld on request



ASK MINT
FINANCIAL PLAN

Diversification is beneficial, but to determine whether allocating to real estate is the right decision, we must understand the value of your existing portfolio—60% equity mutual fund exposure—and how it fits into your overall asset allocation. If I assume a portfolio of around ₹1 crore, with 60% in equity, then investing additional ₹75 lakh into real estate may not be a good idea, as it tilts your asset allocation to a single asset class.

Real estate, though stable in perception, comes with challenges such as liquidity constraints, higher transaction costs and longer holding periods. Over-allocation to such an

asset class can reduce flexibility in your portfolio, especially when funds are needed for important goals.

However, if your portfolio is closer to, say, ₹5 crore, with ₹3 crore already in equity, allocating ₹75 lakh to real estate makes sense. In this case, it will form roughly 15% of your portfolio, acting as diversification without overexposing you to one asset class. To plan for goals like children's education, follow a bucketing strategy.

There is nothing wrong with starting with equity investments for growth, but as you approach the goal time-

line, gradually reduce risk. For example, if the goal is 8 years away, start shifting funds from equity to fixed income instruments from the 6th year onwards to protect the corpus from market volatility.

For retirement planning, maintain three buckets: The next 2-3 years of expenses should be kept in fixed income instruments to ensure stability and liquidity. The following 4-5 years can be allocated to a hybrid portfolio, such as balanced advantage funds, providing growth and downside protection.

The remaining corpus can remain invested in aggressive assets like equity mutual funds for inflation-beating returns. Rebalance your portfolio by shifting money from bucket 3 to bucket 2, and from bucket 2 to bucket 1 over time. This approach helps manage risk, ensure liquidity, and avoid uncertainties as you move closer to your financial goals.

Rakshit H.D. is a CFP and head of digital sales at God Teller.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at mintmoney@livemint.com and get them answered by industry experts.

Compare NRE FD rates

Non-resident Indians (NRIs) can open NRE fixed deposits with different Indian banks. The benefit of an NRE deposit is that it can be opened simply by making inward remittance to India in any freely convertible currency. Another benefit is that the interest earned on NRE deposits are tax-free and the deposit is fully repatriable, allowing NRIs to transfer funds back to their country of residence without restrictions. NRE FDs can be opened and managed online too with Indian banks. NRIs can also obtain loan against NRE FDs which can be used for a variety of purposes. These loans can be granted to the NRI in India or outside India (by overseas branch of Indian banks) or even to third parties.



NRE Term Deposits Interest Rates (%) upto ₹1 crore				
	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.90-7.00	6.90-7.15	7.00-7.10	7.00-7.15
YES Bank	6.65-7.00	6.90-7.00	7.00	6.75
RBL Bank	7.00-7.20	7.20	7.00-7.20	6.70
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	6.70-6.75	6.75-7.25	6.65	6.60
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.60-7.10	6.60	6.60	6.60
IndusInd Bank	6.75-7.00	6.90	6.50-6.90	6.50-6.65
Dhanlaxmi Bank	6.25-6.95	6.25-6.50	6.50-7.00	6.50-6.60
ICICI Bank	6.25-6.30	6.30-6.45	6.45-6.50	6.50
Axis Bank	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.45	6.45
Federal Bank	6.25-6.70	6.40	6.40-6.75	6.40
Karur Vysya Bank	6.20-6.55	6.55	6.55	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.50-6.70	6.70	6.40	6.25
Canara Bank	6.25-6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
City Union Bank	6.50-7.00	6.50	6.25-6.50	6.25
HDFC Bank	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.40-6.50	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	6.40-6.60	6.40	6.10	6.10

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 7 April 2026. Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table. The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

GOPAKUMAR WARRIOR/MINT

Source: BankBazar

RBI POLICY: WHY THE END OF THE 'GOLDDILOCKS' PHASE ISN'T A JOLT FOR INVESTORS

POWER POINT
JOYDEEP SEN
Respond to this column at feedback@livemint.com

Golddilocks refers to a situation that is just right—neither too hot nor too cold. Derived from the fairy tale character who prefers things in the middle, it describes an optimal, balanced condition in an economy or system.

In the previous policy review on 6 February 2026, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) governor highlighted that this was the prevailing condition in India, and rightfully so. The gross domestic product (GDP) growth rate was north of 7% and inflation much lower than the target of 4%. No other country in the world could boast of such a situation at that point in time.

Now, as we all know, the needle has moved quite noticeably. War in West Asia. Oil on the boil in global markets. Rupee gasping until the recent pullback. Inflation looking upwards once again. Question marks on GDP growth in the months ahead

encourage GDP growth but high enough to keep inflation in check and expectations anchored. A balancing act is required, not just from RBI but also by central banks around the world facing similar pressures.

This policy review was particularly important because it showed RBI's road map for navigating these challenging times and uncertain global conditions. To put it in numbers, the GDP growth estimate for 2026-27 is 6.9%, against 7.6% in 2025-26. Consumer Price Index (CPI)-linked inflation is now projected at 4.6% in 2026-27 for the full fiscal year. The previous inflation projection, on 6 February 2026, was 4.1% for the first half of the fiscal year (April to September 2026). While a downward revision of GDP growth and an upward revision of inflation were widely expected, we now have a clearer picture of the underlying data. RBI's inflation forecast is based on an assumed crude price of \$85 per barrel and an exchange rate of 194 to the dollar for 2026-27.

Projected inflation at 4.6% is just a shade higher than RBI's target of 4%. There is no pressing need for a rate hike as we can live with 4.6% inflation. We are looking at a long pause on the repo rate, currently at 5.25%, over the next year or so. However, this downward pressure on growth gives RBI a clear reason to hold interest rates steady rather than hike them. Ultimately, the transition away from a "Golddilocks" economy is more of a gradual shift than a sudden shock.

The market reaction has been positive. Equity indices are up



the policy announcement. If the ceasefire holds and crude oil prices ease, there could be relief on inflation as India imports a large chunk of its crude oil requirement, apart from other goods.

What does this mean for your investments?
The policy review, at the margin, is positive for investments. Low inflation is positive for both equity and bond markets. The

that we need not panic about inflationary pressures just yet.

Sanguine GDP growth is good for equity markets. Considering the spate of downward revisions in GDP growth expectations from various agencies, including RBI's 6.9% projection, provides confidence. The central bank's projection of \$85 oil for 2026-27—regardless of whether it proves accurate—signals their expectation that the current spikes in prices will eventually subside.

Assuming the MPC maintains the status quo on interest rate over the next year or so, there will not be any need to shuffle your portfolio based on this.

Going forward, even if the two-week ceasefire holds, geopolitical tensions are here to stay. The international rule-of-law framework is broken. This means gold prices will likely remain supported as central banks move away from other assets towards gold. You should have a 10-15% gold allocation in your portfolio.

While any economy will be affected by a global crisis, India remains a structural growth story with fundamentals strong enough to withstand even significant shocks. To maintain a balanced portfolio, investors should include some exposure to global equities and overseas markets for diversification. Meanwhile, with yields unlikely to drop significantly, debt investments



OUR VIEW



RBI caution is valid: The dust of war hangs hazy

Its decision to leave policy rates unchanged is consistent with economic uncertainty despite tentative signs of war relief. The central bank must stay alert but the Centre may need to act

The Gulf war's two-week break for truce talks has spelt relief for the global economy. But until a reliable peace pact is forged, hostilities could erupt again—even before the West Asian dust-up settles to offer us some clarity on its impact. So, it was sensible of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to have held its monetary policy steady. As widely expected, its rate-setting panel voted in unison to hold the repo rate—at which RBI lends short-term money to banks—unchanged at 5.25%. The rates at which it absorbs and injects liquidity (in last-resort cases) stay a quarter of a percentage point below and above that key rate, respectively. The news of a ceasefire had broken only hours before RBI's policy announcement; that it found mention in governor Sanjay Malhotra's speech was not remarkable, given its potential significance, but since the war's disruption has already caused plenty of damage, RBI's forecasts may need only minor revisions if peace does come to prevail. RBI sees inflation hitting 4.6% in 2026-27, up from 4.2% predicted earlier, largely as a result of inflationary impulses spawned by supply snarls. India's GDP growth is seen dipping to 6.9% in 2026-27 from 7.6% last year. Since supply shocks unsettle both price stability and the economy's expansion, RBI could not have tried to tackle either without being sure of which was at greater risk.

Growth seems more secure. In RBI's assessment, rural and urban demand are in fine fettle, with both expected to strengthen further. A boost from last year's GST reset has helped and farm conditions are seen to be broadly favourable. RBI also expects a revival in private investment to sustain amid high capacity utilization and strong credit growth. Whether overall capi-

tal formation can regain its past record, however, remains unclear. The farm sector's prospects, meanwhile, seem clouded by the possibility of El Niño dryness this year that may hurt post-monsoon harvests; freak rainfall in the north may already have hurt spring crops. On the whole, this may impact inflation more than output. In any case, our general price levels are unlikely to escape the war's overhang. The ripple effects of costlier energy imports and a weakened rupee may appear less severe than feared just days ago, but the crude-oil price that RBI assumed for its math was raised by just \$15 to \$85 a barrel this fiscal year. While Brent has softened, oil-and-gas volatility may persist. Where hydrocarbon prices might settle will be hard to gauge before the Gulf's sandstorm settles to reveal the region's supply capacity.

And then, there is also the rupee to think about. Our currency began weakening well before the war started stoking inflation and skewing our external balances. Malhotra reiterated RBI's policy of not targeting any specific level and acting only to curb excessive volatility. This would reassure those who are wary of a currency peg in the guise of a managed float, but not those hurt by drastic depreciation. While RBI's efforts to curb forex speculation have made a difference, if capital inflows do not stage a comeback, it may need to use other measures to attract dollars (perhaps from non-resident Indians); or even tighten outflows. Why foreign investments have thinned out, however, is a question for the government to mull over. Some of it may be beyond its control, but India's taxation of capital gains has grown in recent years; easing this burden might send a signal that draws global investors back to Indian assets, thus lending the rupee some stability.

MY VIEW | MYTHS AND MANTRAS

Smart money lessons from the success of Rakesh Jhunjhunwala

Control over one's mind and understanding stock-market patterns hold the key to investing success



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If I ask which is the most volatile investment option among fixed deposits, Public Provident Fund, equity and liquid mutual funds, everyone will get the answer right: equity. Of course, there are assets like cryptocurrency that are even more volatile, but we are not going there now.

When we look back on index charts for various stock markets globally over the decades, it all looks so simple: the market went down here, then went up, and obviously you would have either remained invested through the ups and downs or bought more at the bottom. Of course. Nothing could be simpler. And you are smart.

Unfortunately, in the here and now, you see only the down leg in the graph without any clarity on if, when and how an upward move will come. It is then that the voice in your head begins to panic and pushes you towards the exit.

Volatility in theory appears fine, and maybe at some level, we all think that it means a 20% return in one year and maybe only 5% the next. The reality can be a decline of 15% or even 25% in the next period.

The 'superpower' that's needed for market success is actually quite simple, at least in theory: understand and act on the fact that stock market returns are lumpy, not even. Everyone in the late Rakesh Jhunjhunwala, or at

least his investment results. There are many theories about his investment methods and philosophies, and why he succeeded and managed to make a fortune investing exclusively in Indian equities.

So was his superpower his selection of stocks? As someone who knew him first hand, I would say not. He bought literally hundreds of stocks and was equally passionate about many of them. But he ended up making almost his entire fortune in three or four of them: Titan, Crisil, Lupin and a couple more.

His trick was something else entirely. A book about him, *The Big Bull of Dalal Street: How Rakesh Jhunjhunwala Made His Fortune*, makes all sorts of assertions about his methods and abilities. But the line that stood out for me was a quote from Jhunjhunwala himself: "Not every year I make money. I make money in spurts, like 1989-92, 2003-07, 2009-11. In 1994-99, I would not have made any trading income."

This should be the Eureka moment for other investors. Not only do stock market returns vary from year-to-year, there can also be long periods of no returns at all. On the other hand, you can make mega returns in just two or three good years. After all, between 2003 and 2007, the Indian market indexes themselves went up about six times.

Sounds great? But note that this was after nine years of net zero returns and a 40% decline from the top. If you remain disciplined through downturns or frustrating sideways moves, which can go on for what may seem like an interminably long time, you will be way ahead of the general investor pack.

Unfortunately, if you get out of the market during scary times, you'll never be able to catch up when the upmove comes.

As you may have heard me repeat over the years, if you missed out on just the 10 best days of the Indian stock market in 40-plus years, you would have lost out on two-thirds of the total

market returns over this period.

Miss out on the 30 best days over 40 long years and you have missed 90% of the returns you could have made. The pattern is the same for the S&P 500, in whose case missing out on the 100 best days in 100 years would bring your returns to negative territory!

As it happens, these sharp upmoves usually come when there is fear, anxiety and uncertainty in markets. Markets rarely go up that rapidly in a bull phase. For example, if you did not get back into the markets by the last week of March 2020 after the horrifying covid crash at the beginning of the month, you'd have missed the 30% return over the next five weeks, both in India and globally. It is a gap that would then have been impossible to bridge no matter how smart an investor you are.

In an ideal world, you would get out before a big crash and get back in time, something we at First Global did manage to do during February and March 2020. However, this kind of timing doesn't always work out even for professional investors.

Overall, it does more damage to your portfolio returns if you are out of the market at the wrong time than if you remain invested and face a decline in your portfolio.

Equanimity, discipline and an ability to stick to your long-term plans—basically control over your mind—hold the key to successful investing.

If you have to learn one thing from Rakesh Jhunjhunwala's investing career, it is this:

Many others have started touting these statistics only in the recent past, but I have written about this in considerable depth in my book, *Money, Myths and Mantras*, laying out precisely how long downturns have lasted in the past and what would have happened to your investment portfolio.

My advice, as always, favours proper, well-considered asset allocation and as little tinkering as possible with this allocation thereafter.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

A person who has not made peace with his losses is likely to accept gambles that would be unacceptable to him otherwise.

DANIEL KAHNEMAN

THEIR VIEW

Prospect Theory explains how war risks got mispriced

TULSI JAYAKUMAR

entering 2026 seemed to offer high-probability gains. Iran's defences had been weakened by the 12-day Israeli-US campaign of June 2025. The International Atomic Energy Agency had documented Iran's uranium enrichment approaching weapons-

launched hundreds of missiles at Israel and US bases, and struck Gulf states that professed neutrality. This was not irrationality but textbook highly-likely-loss behaviour. The Hormuz gambit illustrates this well. Almost a fifth of the world's oil flows via that

was an unlikely outcome dressed as strategy. The US claimed a shifting menu of war objectives: preventing a nuclear weapon in Iran's hands, securing its oil resources, achieving regime change. This multiplicity suggests fourfold-pattern thinking: some aims were

supplies and steel manufacturing across Asia, and that killing Iran's supreme leader would take away the one figure with the authority to call off Iran's Revolutionary Guards, making de-escalation harder.

India, which sources much of its hydro-



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As the US-Iran war enters a fragile two-week ceasefire, with no clear endgame in sight, one may well ask how and why the world reached this situation. Wars are rarely accidents. At their core, they are bets, and can hence be viewed through the lens of risk—not in a vague rhetorical sense, but by means of rigorous psychological analysis of the kind that forms part of Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky's Prospect Theory, particularly its four-fold pattern of risk attitudes. This framework maps human behaviour into four quadrants based on whether an outcome involves gains or losses and whether its probability is high or low. Applied to the US-Israel-Iran war, it reveals how every major actor is behaving as the theory predicts and why such predictable behaviour is not the same as wisdom.

When there is a high probability of large gains, Prospect Theory predicts people become risk-averse, preferring to lock in what is almost certain rather than gamble for more. For the US, the military calculus

grade, providing a pretext. The window for the US to lock in prospective gains was real, with Iran seeming barely months away from nuclear-breakout capability. The question was not whether to act, but when to take a sure gain. On 28 February, war began, setting in motion the dynamics that have now been paused but not resolved.

If the likelihood of a bad outcome is high, however, the psychology flips: people seek risk. When people expect to lose, they gamble, which explains why cornered states do not capitulate. Iran entered 2026 facing losses across all dimensions. Its economy was in free-fall, with inflation exceeding 40%, and its regional network of proxies like Hezbollah, Hamas and the Houthis had been almost dismantled by Israeli operations since 2023. And once the war began, its supreme leader was dead within hours of the first strike. A rational actor facing certain humiliation might have chosen a negotiated surrender. But Prospect Theory predicts the opposite. Iran closed the Strait of Hormuz,

choke-point, including Iran's own exports. But a regime staring at extinction does not optimize policy for trade flows. It reaches for a lever that might force a ceasefire or make the enemy suffer too. The third quadrant is a domain where there is a very low probability of significant gains. In such cases, people overweight that small likelihood, paying more than what the mathematically expected payoff would justify for a long shot at a transformative outcome. It is why people buy lottery tickets and why states sometimes launch wars that the math does not favour.

Several US aims fell in this quadrant. The hope of regime change in Tehran with a democratic transition delivering a pro-West regime and an end to four decades of enmity

near-certain, others were lottery tickets.

The behaviour of warring states may seem bizarre but it fits an academic model of risk dispositions

The problem is that overweighting low-probability gains leads to miscalibrated decisions. Washington underestimated the tail risks of its bet, including a multifront missile war that has touched NATO territory, the Caucasus area and the Levant, apart from states across the Gulf from Iran.

Quadrant 4 is the most dangerous and relevant to the world. When losses are unlikely but catastrophic,

Prospect Theory observes that people underweight them. Just as they overpay for small chances of gain, they under-prepare for small chances of catastrophe. The low-probability, high-consequence risks of this conflict were visible well before 28 February. It was known that a Strait of Hormuz blockade would disrupt fertilizer

carbon needs from the Gulf, also sits in the fourth quadrant. Until recently, India underestimated the probability of a prolonged supply disruption. But we now face a different reality, even if the US-Iran ceasefire offers tenuous relief.

Prospect Theory's fourfold pattern is not a framework for predicting outcomes but for understanding how actors behave under uncertainty and why decision-makers make the same errors. In its hunt for certain gains, the US was blind to catastrophic tail risks, while an Iran facing certain losses took big risks in ways that maximized regional pain. Everyone bought the lottery ticket of transformative victory while under-insuring against unlikely disasters. The ceasefire may have paused the disruption, but the world is paying a premium in energy bills, disrupted trade and the realization that a war nobody fully predicted has compounding costs. The fourfold pattern tells us that this was not a failure of intelligence, but of risk literacy.

These are the author's personal views.

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THEIR VIEW

MINT CURATOR

RBI's rate-setting panel is in step with other major central banks

The Monetary Policy Committee's call to bide time is sensible as uncertainty lingers despite the temporary truce in West Asia



MYTHILI BHUSHAN RATHI
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Over the past three days, 6-8 April 2026, the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) six-member Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) that is responsible for setting the policy interest rate (repo) has, doubtless, burnt the proverbial midnight oil deliberating on the growth-inflation trade-off. As expected, it has concluded, like most central banks, that it is best to mark time.

The ceasefire in the West Asia conflict, announced just a little over an hour before US President Donald Trump's deadline to "wipe out an entire civilisation" waste end (and, coincidentally, just hours before RBI governor Sanjay Malhotra's statement), brings only a temporary reprieve (if a fortnight). It is far from clear whether the ceasefire will hold. More importantly, whether it will lead to lasting peace in a region that has been the scene of more wars than perhaps any other and is crucial to global energy security.

Unlike markets that tend to react like a cat on a hot tin roof—the Sensex shot up more than 3.6% in the first half hour of trade on Wednesday—central banks are expected to know better; and react in a more measured and mature fashion. RBI did just that. It kept its policy repo rate (at which it infuses liquidity into the banking system) unchanged at 5.25% and retained its neutral policy stance. It can take comfort that it is not the only major central bank to have opted to keep its powder dry. Rather, it joins central banks like the US Federal Reserve, Bank of England, European Central Bank and Bank of Japan, all of which have preferred to wait and watch.

Ironically, the growth-inflation mix facing each of these central banks is different. In the US, the growth continues to defy expectations, with the latest projection for the year at 2.2%, while annual inflation at 2.4% is above its target of 2%. In contrast, growth in the UK is moribund—GDP expanded by just 0.1% in the October–December quarter, while inflation at 3% is above its target of 2%. In Japan, headline retail inflation stood at 3.2% while growth was just 1.1% (International Monetary Fund, 2025 estimates).

So what explains the fact that these central banks, all of which face disparate conditions, decided to hold rates at their March 2026 meetings? Apart from the fact that inflation is above the target in all three, the common factor is that the outlook is so clouded by geopolitical uncertainty that it is simply not possible to make meaningful projections or take any action till the fog enveloping the world economy clears a little. In such a scenario, it is always more prudent to wait and watch.

Likewise with RBI and its rate-setting commit-



ty market, but thanks to spillovers, a host of other sectors, notably gas, fertilizers, insurance, transport and logistics. Our overwhelming import dependence for energy means second-order inflation effects cannot be ignored. Though retail inflation may seem benign at 3.2% in February and the March number may also post within the target range of 2-6%, it is only a matter of time before inflation ticks up, driven by supply disruptions and a weaker rupee. For now, the pass-through to retail consumers has been suppressed by the government's decision to lower excise and customs duties on a host of petroleum products. But that is, at best, a breather.

In governor Malhotra's words, "The unprecedented challenge for the global economy—higher prices and lower global growth—[means] monetary policy faces a difficult trade-off—anchoring inflation expectations through policy tightening while minimizing its impact on growth." The "intensity and duration of the conflict in West Asia and the resultant damage to energy and other infrastructure add risk to the inflation and growth outlooks." Faced with this conundrum, the MPC expects growth to fall from 7.6% in

is expected to more than double—yes, you read that right—from 2.1% last fiscal year to 4.6% this fiscal.

"Headline inflation," notes the statement, "remains contained and below the target, but upside risks to the inflation outlook have increased, driven by increased energy price pressures and probable weather disturbances affecting food prices." But with core inflation (i.e. inflation stripped of food and fuel prices) projected at 4.4% in 2026-27 and real interest rates perilously close to zero in the third quarter, inflation is clearly a bigger cause for concern than growth at the moment. Indeed, the MPC argues that "the fundamentals of the Indian economy are on a stronger footing, providing it with greater resilience to withstand shocks now than in the past." Whether they are good enough to deal with this latest shock—which the International Energy Agency describes as the "worst energy crisis in history"—remains to be seen.

Yet, given that the economy is facing a supply shock and monetary policy is ill-equipped to deal with supply shocks, one cannot but agree with the MPC. "It is prudent to wait and watch the changing

'Chinamaxxing': How it might help Asian cities out of hot oil

They should follow China's lead in electrifying urban transport



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'Chinamaxxing' is a trend of people emulating Chinese habits. ISTOCKPHOTO

For the emerging megacities of Asia, the oil crisis that spread out from the Strait of Hormuz is like the acute phase of a chronic condition. The largest migration in human history is filling their streets and alleyways to bursting point. Urbanization and births will add a billion more people between now and 2050. Jakarta and Dhaka, with 42 million and 37 million people respectively, have overtaken Tokyo at 33 million as the world's biggest metropolises. Delhi, Shanghai, Guangzhou, Manila, Kolkata, Seoul, Karachi, and Bangkok aren't far behind. Keeping that many people on the move is a challenge at the best of times. When the price of road fuel doubles, it becomes a nightmare.

The good news is that one country has been through this cycle already. China. It offers a guide for how to cut oil import bills and transport costs for citizens, reduce pollution from noise and exhaust smoke, and make urban life less unpleasant. Asia's megacities can follow the 'Chinamaxxing' trend that's taken over social media lately.

From the perspective of a rich country, it's easy to think the electrification of transport is all about passenger cars. In emerging Asia, however, the real gains are to be made in scooters, motorbikes, trucks and buses.

Two-wheelers are most ripe for EV disruption. Parts of Asia are already moving towards hard restrictions on petrol-run bikes and scooters. Most Chinese cities have had such restrictions for a decade or more, making them motorbike-free zones. Nearly 60% of sales are already fully electric.

Falling battery costs are now changing the game across the region. In India, a base model Ola S1 electric scooter costs about ₹90,000, compared to ₹78,000 for a petrol-powered Honda Activa. That's close enough to make the electric bike a serious proposition, especially considering savings on maintenance and fuel. With small batteries that can typically be swapped and charged at home, such bikes don't need costly infrastructure either.

They also offer a quick route to making the urban environment more pleasant. Conventional motorbikes and scooters disproportionately contribute to particulate pollution, and just one can make as much noise as 30 electric bikes. Visit EV-dominated major Chinese cities these days and it is striking how quiet they can be.

Unfortunately, the sector elsewhere has been held back by baffling policy reversals. Indonesia, the third-largest two-wheeler market, announced the cancellation of its

from 28% to 18%. That's still higher than the 5% tax levied on EV bikes, but the latter's reduced discount has made electric models less price competitive. Policies encouraging a wholesale switch should be expanded and held in place.

Trucks will be a harder fix, but there are opportunities there too. Asian megacities, including those in China, already restrict deliveries at night time to prevent vehicles crumming up the road—but that creates its own problems, because noisy diesel engines ruin everybody's sleep. Smaller trucks are already cost-competitive once you factor in fuel expenses, but operators still lack an incentive to switch. Cities should complement their night-delivery rules with charges for non-electric deliveries, similar to those employed in Europe's low-emission zones. The revenue can be used to provide low-cost loans for drivers to switch to cleaner vehicles.

Buses form the last part of the picture. In China, two-thirds of the fleet and 97% of city bus sales are now electric. Typically, these services are state-run, so governments are well placed to act. Though they are a small share of road traffic and fuel consumption, using fleet renewals to stimulate local supply chains will help build capability in manufacturing other heavy-duty vehicles, such as trucks.

We can't ignore the EV car fleet, but that's going to be the toughest nut to crack for emerging megacities. It will require comprehensive EV-charging networks and costly subsidies, given the sheer scale of the potential market. It will also funnel money to affluent citizens least in need of it. Metro systems, being built across Asia at a furious pace, are likewise a relatively big-ticket way to tackle fuel, pollution and traffic problems.

Governments should certainly remove any subsidies that still incentivize petrol and diesel usage. But making the transition to electric cars and mass-transit railway systems is a challenge that will take billions of dollars and many years to solve.

For governments struggling with the fiscal headaches spawned by the Iran war, Chinamaxxing two-wheeler, truck and bus fleets will be far quicker, and cheaper.

Fix that problem, and you'll also make

MY VIEW | ACUTE ANGLE

Is this a turning point in world politics? Don't bet on it

SANJOY CHAKRAVORTY



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The turmoil of the last year-and-a-half—tariff wars and physical wars (Iran, Gaza, Lebanon, Ukraine), the abduction of a head of state and assassination of another, territorial ambitions and tattered alliances—has led to claims that the Pax Americana of stable global institutions managing commerce and conflict has ended. If that is true, what comes next? This uncertainty has fostered many forecasts of the future of global politics by policy pundits. Consider the analysis of Hal Brands, a historian at Johns Hopkins University and the American Enterprise Institute. Brands is a well-known neoconservative with strong ties to the Republican Party's security and foreign policy establishment. He has been called a "war intellectualizer/lover" for his hawkish positions on US power. Agree with him or not, his views carry weight. In a recent article in *Foreign Policy* magazine, Brands identifies three possible scenarios for the coming era.

The most likely outcome, one that Brands

argues has felt inevitable for the last several years with the rise of China, is of a world divided into two blocs led by Washington and Beijing. This bipolar world would resemble the Cold War of US-Soviet rivalry, in which an "array of swing states—from India to Saudi Arabia, Brazil to Indonesia—would align selectively with these blocs while maneuvering opportunistically between them." If recent US actions are indeed meant to hasten the creation of this new bipolar world order, I find it difficult to understand how the US would achieve this by alienating its existing allies (in Europe) and starting an unnecessary war with Iran. If one pole of the new cold war is supposed to be a liberal democratic bloc, it is hard to imagine how threatening Canada and Greenland could consolidate it. In fact, the actions being taken now suggest a brazen 'go it alone' rather than 'let's do it together' approach. They signal a desire for a unipolar world in defiance of its bipolar reality.

The second possibility suggested by Brands is an era not of two blocs but of several empires in which regional giants carve out domains of control. The US takes the Americas, China takes the far east and Russia expands into Europe. Meanwhile, "India grabs for primacy in South Asia and the

Indian Ocean. Turkey stakes out a post-Ottoman domain at the intersection of Europe, the Middle East, and Africa. Israel, Saudi Arabia, and other contenders jostle for hegemony in the Red Sea complex that links the Persian Gulf and the Horn of Africa." Again, the logic of this escapes me. Why is this in the US interest? Why would a smaller area of control be desirable for a global hegemon? Why would so much money be spent and blood spilt to end up with less influence? Brands' third scenario is one of anarchy, in which the US "goes rogue" and becomes a "brutish, norm-busting superpower" that "engages in aggressive territorial expansion," "appropriates, through force or coercion, vital resources from weaker powers" and "demands ever-greater tribute from dependencies." In consequence, every nation hustles alone to gain or survive the concept of a 'sovereign nation' may itself become archaic. Europe and Japan rearm. The world reverts to a primal state last seen

during periods like the "scramble for Africa" and other imperialistic nightmares. Trade and innovations dwindle and 'development' becomes a forgotten dream as the world's inhabitants lose income, health and knowledge and return to a Hobbesian 'state of nature' with a "war of all against all." How could anyone desire this? All three scenarios assume that we are at a major turning point in history because the rules and institutions nurtured over the last 80 years can no longer maintain peace, stability and commerce. Since these institutions are failing—so the argument goes—their primary architect and beneficiary has taken a sledgehammer to destroy them. One must assume that this architect has a vision of the future in which it benefits even more. Yet, none of the scenarios outlined above comes close to making the hegemon more powerful. So, is this moment truly a turning point or merely an episode? Let's consider a fourth scenario that Brands does not mention: This

moment is an aberration; i.e., an outlier, not a turning point. Leadership in the US will change with the election cycle. Democracies will reaffirm their faith in the global order that has kept them safe for decades. They might tweak the rules—like efficient organisms, they adapt—so that such an aberration does not easily recur. Great power rivalry will resume regular service as the US and China try to build larger alliances through reciprocity and incentives rather than threats. Nations will continue to compete for technological and productivity gains as they figure out how to handle existential threats like AI, climate change, and the unprecedented concentration of power in individuals. Finally, we must examine the very urge to imagine turning points. Granted, a turning point is more interesting than a straight line. Also, to many people, today's global situation feels overwhelming, a radically unpleasant departure from the recent past. This feeling may have more power to influence the future than the actions that produce it. If sufficiently large numbers feel that things are not right, in a competitive democracy, they have the power to change course. Turning-point talk may obsess pundits of security, but let us raise at least one cheer for the most boring of concepts: equilibrium.

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BUSINESS OF LIFE • CULTURE



Turning erasures into compassionate art



For her haunting new series of works, artist Saubiya Chasmawala looked afresh at old family photo albums for inspiration

Zeemal Nagree
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In my mind, I compare looking at photographs of one's childhood to throwing a beloved object into the sea. It returns, unaltered, but it appears altered, and we cannot help but admire the object for the novel and unexpected attributes it reveals itself to have. It reminds us that we too have transformed in the interim, washed by



were the focus. The letters appeared like gestures, recording the movements of her body. At times, the letters were recognizable but they did not form words that held meaning and were not meant to be read out. This choice leant into the title *Batin*, which in Sufism refers to the hidden, the symbolic, the secret. But there was also an acceptance and a celebration that Chasmawala was enacting. South Asian Muslims often learn to read Arabic letters without learning the language itself, and this ossification of meaning within a religious practice that is supposed to hold deep meaning was the paradox that she was confronting. "There was an acceptance after that. I spent so much time in my childhood reading and reciting those verses, and they will always remain a part of me," she explained. Some of these paintings were made with ink and others with saffron as a pigment, often used in her family to write verses on paper that are then dissolved into water to make healing potions. In the past few months, Chasmawala has returned to her family albums, looking afresh at the compositions her father painstakingly made on film during their travels to museums in Iran, Iraq, Yemen, Saudi Arabia, Egypt, Israel and parts of western India in the 1990s. A selection of those paintings, with Arabic letters in gold leaf inscribed on the photos, were also showcased at the India Art Fair in February.



Nirvana is one of several classic bands featured in the collection.

Fan recordings become online treasure trove

The Adam Jacobs Collection has gigs from seminal indie and punk bands

Agencies
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On 8 July 1989, a young music fan named Adam Jacobs, with a compact Sony cassette recorder in his pocket, went to see an up-and-coming rock band from Washington for their debut show in Chicago. After a blast of guitar feedback, 20-year-old Kurt Cobain announced to the crowd at the small club called Dreamerz: "Hello, we're Nirvana. We're from Seattle." With that, the band, then a quartet, launched into the riff-heavy first song, *School*. Jacobs surreptitiously recorded the performance, documenting the fledgling band in raw, fiery form more than two years before Nirvana's global breakthrough with the album *Nevermind*. Jacobs went on to record more than 10,000 concerts, with increasingly sophisticated equipment. Now a group of devoted volunteers in the US and Europe is methodically cataloguing, digitizing, and uploading them one by one. The growing Adam Jacobs Collection is an internet treasure trove for music lovers, especially for fans of indie and punk rock during the 1980s through the early 2000s, when the scene blossomed and became mainstream. The collection features early-in-career performances from alternative and experimental artists such as R.E.M., The Cure, The Pixies, The Replacements, Depeche Mode, Stereolab, Sonic Youth and Björk. All of it is slowly becoming available for streaming and free download at the non-profit online repository Internet Archive. Jacobs' first recording was in 1984. By the time Jacobs snuck his tape recorder into that Nirvana gig, he had been recording concerts for five years. He doesn't remember offhand what that first concert was in 1984, but he

The collection features performances from R.E.M., The Cure, The Pixies and more

It is even stranger to look at photographs of someone else's childhood. We don't have the memories or the myths to enter them and we must look for portals that emerge from our own experiences. To me, the photographs that artist Saubha Chasmawala has used for almost a decade in her paintings are nevertheless quite familiar. I have known first-hand the kind of gravesites that her family made pilgrimages to when she was a child. I know the abstraction that such a visit requires—one is there to attend to a haunting presence, to reverse it, and to acknowledge the power that a formless force can have on one's spiritual imagination.

Chasmawala has worked on these photographs in different ways over time. Early on, she would conceal the faces of the visitors—all members of her family—making us think we are looking at ghosts. She has made incisions into the surfaces of the paper, bound bodies with thread, and expressed a sense of longing and frustration through washes of white that obliterate the surrounding landscape, allowing us

(clockwise from top) Recent works such as *Untitled 278* and *Untitled 276* were shown at the last India Art Fair, from the exhibition, *Pilgrimage of Historical Oversight*.

COURTESY: THE ARTIST

viewers to travel from the particular event depicted to a contemplation of wounding. How porous the appearance of injury and healing can be when it is distilled into a moment!

The 35-year-old artist now works on the photographs in a more measured manner. Some examples of this current work can be seen at *Intersections: Sites of Becoming*, on view till 30 April at Arthshila, New Delhi, to celebrate 50 years of the Indira Gandhi Foundation. The exhibition and public programmes feature a cross-section of practitioners supported by the Foundation over the past five decades.

During a conversation with Chasmawala, the idea of the wound as an opening seems persist-

ently present in her mind. "In art school I began questioning everything, and it reflected in my work as well, with incisions on canvas and paper," says the artist, recalling her time at the Maharaja Sayajirao University in Baroda. The incisions in those early paintings were meant to take out Arabic letters that she had written, symbolizing a rift, the unmooring of belief from her sense of self. But looking further, the incisions eventually led to a new space, a kind of abstraction in which it was possible to contemplate the infinite through a distance.

Chasmawala's paintings in her solo show *Batin*, at Tarq, Mumbai, in 2019, captured this shift. The sinuous forms of the Arabic script

"In art school I began questioning everything, and it reflected in my work, with incisions on canvas and paper"

A decade ago, not used to work with these photographs came from the distance she felt from her family for the first time while being away at an art residency. These works, however, attempt repair. The frenetic gestures of erasure are more carefully considered through the use of contained shapes and washes. "I was looking at them with more compassion," says the artist, "I felt a greater sense of peace." From this sense of resolution, Chasmawala is moving towards abstraction.

During our call, she shows me a work in progress, a lattice in gold bound with black thread, a filament symbolizing the way people give shape to a wish. This turn in Chasmawala's practice continues her engagement with devotion, from a place that brings together the charged experiences of her childhood reflected through a study of abstraction. "Perhaps, I have always communicated better through erasures," she reflects. Sometimes, what disappears becomes most visible.

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taped it with a tiny dictaphone-type device that he borrowed from his grandmother. A short time later, he bought the Sony Walkman-style tape recorder. When that broke, he used his home console cassette machine stuffed in a backpack.

"I was using, at times, pretty lacklustre equipment, simply because I had no money to buy anything better," he said. Later, he moved on to digital audio tape, or DAT, and, as technology progressed, to solid-state digital recorders.

In 2023, a volunteer with the Internet Archive reached out to suggest his collection be preserved. Once a month, Brian Emerick makes the trip from the Chicago suburbs to Jacobs' house in the city. Emerick's job is to transfer the analogue recordings to digital files that can be sent to other volunteers who mix and master the shows for upload to the archive.

Emerick estimates he's digitized at least 5,500 shows since late 2024 and that it will take another few years to complete the project. The digital files are claimed by a dozen or so volunteer-engineers in the US, UK, and Germany who provide the metadata and clean up the audio.

Often, the hardest job is figuring out song titles. Occasionally, Jacobs kept helpful notes, but the volunteers frequently spend days consulting each other, searching and even reaching out to artists to make sure the set lists are accurately documented.

Mangal Kabyas shed light on Bengal's riverine trade

Poems and devotional stories dating back to the 15th century continue to offer insights into Bengal's waterways

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In 2015, I got a ring-side view to an ambitious regional infrastructure project as India and Bangladesh revived centuries-old inland waterways. This route once moved goods and people not only through both countries but to Bhutan and Nepal as well. The climate benefits and long history made this project relevant. I could feel the pull of the argument as I worked on a feasibility study of reviving the old riverine channels at Tribeni in West Bengal, including a trading port at Balagarh. It reminded me that I was tracing the shipping route of Chand Saudagar from poet Bipradas Pipilai's *Manusamangal Kabya* (or *Manasa Vijay*) dating back to the 15th century. This is the most famous among *saudagar* (Bengali for merchant) characters from Bengal's *Mangal Kabyas*—or narrative religious poems written between 13th–18th century—and *bratakathas*, sacred devotional stories

recited by women during ritualistic fasts. Chand Saudagar's merchant ship used to sail towards the Bay of Bengal from ancient Champak Nagar, or present-day Champaknagar of Purba Bardhaman district of West Bengal, after passing through Tribeni, situated at the confluence of the Ganga, Saraswati and Jamuna. Located a little further down the river, today Balagarh's 600-year-old wooden boat-making industry is seeking Geographical Indication tag based on its mention in the *Mangal Kabyas* as a boat making cluster.

Waterways have long been conduits to evolution of civilizations, bringing in not just goods but also cultural influences. The 54 trans-boundary rivers flowing through the east of the subcontinent, including the Ganga, Padma, Brahmaputra, Jamuna, Barak/Meghna, have long shaped trade and culture. It is hardly surprising, then, that post-medieval literature continues to offer insights into Bengal's waterways.

The *Manusamangal Kabya* mentions that Chand Saudagar loads 14 of his ships with precious stones, pomelos, coconut, betelnuts, fine cotton, bundles of jute, red and black lentils, ginger and turmeric to set sail for a place mentioned simply as the "southern port". Many of the items listed by Bipradas Pipilai in the 15th century are major items that Bengal still exports.

Another significant text is the *Chan-*



Balagarh has a 600-year-old history of wooden boat-making.

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dimangal from the 16th century. Written by Kabikankan Mukandaram Chakrabarti, the story is set around a merchant, Dhanapati, who is ordered by the king to sail to Singhal (Sri Lanka) to build trade relations. The former bids farewell to his pregnant wife to sail down the river Ajay to the Hooghly. He eventually sails past Tribeni, where people from all over the country come for a dip in the river Bhagirathi, and sails down the Bay of Bengal to

Singhal. Things take an unfortunate turn when Dhanapati is imprisoned by the king. Years later, his son, Sripati, sails to Singhal to save his father. His ship is loaded with brassware, jute, Ayurvedic herbs, ginger, vermillion, cloves, carom seeds, blankets, cotton, edible foil and sugar to be bartered with sapphires, ironware, elephants, precious metals, corals, cumin, camphor and nutmeg, among other things. Again, the products

are mentioned in great detail, and match the items being traded even today. The trading posts mentioned along the rivers are those that have been marked as inland water ports in recent projects as well. The poets were not imagining a trading past, but were diligently documenting the riverine economy of 15th–16th century Bengal.

200 years later, in *Ananda Mangal Kabya*, poet Bharatchandra Ray's focus shifts towards the riverine ports of Nadia and Burdhaman, but he doesn't make his protagonists travel across the Bay of Bengal. He describes a European colony of sailors and traders in the third book, *Mansingh*, or *Annapurna Mangal*. The Mughal general, Raja Man Singh, during his voyage down the Bhagirathi to inspect Bengal, comes across quarters of Ingrej (English), Olondj (Dutch), Firing (Portuguese), Farash (French), Dinemar (Danish) and Eleman (from Germany/Aleman), who fire their cannons at his fleet. This was the first mention of the Dutch in Bengali texts, and also the European trading companies present in the region.

The *bratakathas*, much like the *Mangal Kabyas*, feature married women with rather dismissive merchant husbands, who attract the wrath of the mother goddess because of their disparaging attitudes, and are finally saved by the penance of their wives. The most recurrent of the

bratakathas is the *Lokkhi'r Panchali*, a metred narrative in veneration of Goddess Lakshmi that is recited by women on Thursday evenings. In the story, the most prosperous merchant in the city loses all his wealth when seven of his ships sink owing to his contempt of the deity.

Besides trade, the other common thread that runs across all *Mangal Kabyas* and the majority of *bratakathas* is the punishment faced by the protagonist merchants. These are usually in the form of sinking of loaded merchant ships and imprisonment or death of sons. The resolution finally happens when the trader, goaded by his pious wife, prostrates himself in front of the goddess and accepts her power. The ultimate form of forgiveness is that of ships rising from the bottom of the oceans with all the cargo intact. One can argue that the mother goddesses in these texts are embodiments of the indigenous culture, while the *saudagar* community, owing to their exposure to distant lands, represent a shift in perspective. Therefore, the conflict in the texts is just of cultural shifts. The poets haven't just penned stories of veneration but also captured social tensions owing to trade, which exposed traditional communities to different ideas.

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